

RAFFLES INSTITUTION YEAR 6 GENERAL PAPER INFORMATION PACKAGE 2026 Unit: Politics and Governance II - Focusing on Singapore		
	EUs	Pages
1. Introduction and Learning Objectives*	-	2
2. Enduring Understandings and Essential Questions*	-	3
3. For Further Reading/Viewing*	-	4
4. Related Past Year Examination Questions*	-	4-8
Section A: Singapore's Style of Democracy*		
1. Demophobic society: Singapore's allergy to the D-word weakens us*	1 & 3	9-11
2. A defence of Singapore-style democracy	1-3	12-15
3. Singapore needs loving critics	1-3	16-18
4. Leader of the Opposition: A turning point but also a 'double-edged sword'	1 & 3	19-21
5. WP's swift refusal of LO role signals unity behind Pritam Singh, say analysts	1, 4 & 7	21-24
6. Focus on ability, not race in political leadership	1, 4 & 7	25-27
7. Forward SG report lays out roadmap for a new Singapore vision	1, 3-5	28-31
Section B: Negotiating Between Freedom and Stability		
8. 'Hard choices' for Singapore media after controversial law passed	2-3	32-35
9. Trusting Surveillance in Singapore's 'Smart Nation'	2-3	36-38
10. The Myth of 'Trade Offs'*	2, 3 & 5	39-41
11. Concessions Singaporeans make in exchange for effective crisis management	2-4	42-45
Section C: Negotiating Between Inclusiveness and the Common Good		
12. Of race and national identity	2-4	46-48
13. Unpacking the government narrative about 'tribalism' in Singapore	2 & 4	49-52
14. Budget 2026: Accelerating Singapore's growth in a fragmented world	4 & 5	53-55
15. Decision on Section 377A reflects 'Singapore formula' on difficult issues*	2-4	56-58
16. Re-examining Singapore's social security system	5	59-62
17. Immigration and the future of the Singapore identity	5	63-66
Section D: Negotiating Between Domestic Interests and Global Concerns		
18. Singapore's approach to the challenges of an uncertain external environment*	6	67-72
19. Singapore responds to criticism of its climate pledges	6	73-75
20. Imposing sanctions on Russia despite potential costs	6	76-78

****Denotes foundational readings***

1. Introduction

Politics and Governance II builds on fundamental concepts introduced in *Politics and Governance I* and throws the spotlight on Singapore. This package aims to provide information on the Singapore political context to help students better understand and appreciate the complexities of politics and governance in Singapore so as to provide a more informed response to **essays or Application Question answers**. Students are advised to cross-reference the issues raised in this package with those in the Politics I package (e.g. The article on Singapore's Authoritarian prosperity in this package should also be seen as a part of Section 10 in the Politics I package.) In sum, this package was not meant to be a stand-alone compilation of readings, but students should reflect on how these issues are also seen on a global level.

What this package is:

This package is meant to supplement your learning in class by spurring independent thinking and facilitating active discussion on questions and key issues. It is also intended for self-study to gain awareness of the local political context, as well as reflection upon key issues raised. The articles in this package are selected and customised to be of the standard of comprehension expected of an A-level candidate. More difficult articles necessitating a closer read and/or higher order conceptual understanding are flagged out (see Content Page). Related examination questions are highlighted beneath each article—these are meant to guide your thinking and focus your learning. For students interested in going further, links and suggested readings are provided where appropriate. For students requiring background information, particularly with regards to specific countries, additional links are also provided beneath the appropriate articles.

What this package is not:

This package is NOT an exercise in memory and regurgitation, nor is it a “model answer”. General Paper is not about thoughtless memorisation of facts and/or essay scaffolds. It is about close reading of sources, critical analysis of issues raised, and the formation and clear expression of your own logically sound opinions, which are substantiated by factual evidence.

2. Enduring Understandings and Essential Questions:

Enduring Understandings: What will students understand as a result of this unit?

Countries' methods of governance are shaped by a range of historical and socio-economic factors.

EU1: Whatever the choice may be in method of governance, there will be advantages and disadvantages, effects and consequences on the people, economically and socially.

Governance is about negotiation between tensions. These tensions can happen on multiple levels.

EU2: The tension between individual freedom and social stability always requires compromise.

EU3: The tension between individual freedom and the amount of power vested in the state always requires compromise.

EU4: The tension between the needs of the majority and that of the minority always requires compromise.

EU5: The tension between how resources are managed and allocated over the long-term and short-term always requires compromise

EU6: The tension between domestic interests and global pressures always require compromise.

The increasing influence of the media on society has an impact on governance.

EU7: The media can shape the public's perceptions of and behaviour towards political actors/institutions, consequentially aiding or hindering governance.

Essential Questions: What are the essential questions of this unit?

1. Is government necessary and/or avoidable (in all aspects of life)?
2. What is good governance?
3. How do competing values influence political discourse?
4. Can we have effective democratic government without knowledgeable and aware citizens?
5. Is effective governance possible without democratic checks and balances?
6. How much resources should governments be required to allocate to help those who are responsible for their own problems?

3. For Further Reading/Viewing

Recommended Reading:

1. Lee Kuan Yew, From Third World to First: The Singapore Story: 1965-2000.
2. Gretchen Liu, The Singapore Foreign Service: The First 40 Years
3. Cherian George, The Air-conditioned Nation: Essays on the politics of comfort and control (1990-2000)
4. Warren Fernandez, Thinking Allowed?
5. Ghani, Peh, Teo, Lim, et al., Struck by Lightning: Singaporean Voices Post-1965
6. Kishore Mahbubani, The New Asian Hemisphere
7. Donald Low and Sudhir Vadaketh, Hard Choices: Challenging the Singapore Consensus (2014)
8. Carol Soon, Hoe Su Fern (ed.) Singapore Perspectives 2015: Choices
9. Cherian George, Singapore Incomplete (2018)
10. Teo You Yenn, This is What Inequality Looks Like (2018)

4. Related Cambridge and RI Essay Questions

A. Cambridge Exam Questions

1. 'Democracy is the perfect form of government.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. Assess the view that it is always right to challenge injustice. (Cambridge 2024)
3. How realistic is it for countries to implement a national minimum wage for all their workers? (Cambridge 2023)
4. Assess the extent to which all people in your society have the opportunity to achieve their full potential. (Cambridge 2023)
5. Consider the view that people imprisoned for crimes should lose all their rights. (Cambridge 2022)
6. 'Power these days lies more with the people than the politicians.' To what extent is this true? (Cambridge 2021)
7. 'What an individual eats or drinks should not be the concern of the state.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2021)
8. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
9. Is modern technology a benefit or threat to democracy? (Cambridge 2020)
10. 'In a free society, there should be no restrictions on freedom of speech.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2020)
11. To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest? (Cambridge 2020)
12. To what extent can any society claim to be great? (Cambridge 2020)
13. How far should countries have relations with others whose human rights record is poor? (Cambridge 2019)
14. To what extent should income equality be a goal in your society? (Cambridge 2019)
15. Consider the view that social media has more influence than politicians. (Cambridge 2019)
16. A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations. (Cambridge 2019)
17. To what extent is the pursuit of continuous economic growth a desirable goal? (Cambridge 2018)
18. 'In the global village in which we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
19. Discuss the view that all countries have an equal responsibility to counter terrorism. (Cambridge 2018)

20. 'Foreign aid does not solve long-term problems.' To what extent is this a fair viewpoint? (Cambridge 2018)
21. Consider the view that we do not take enough responsibility for our own well-being. (Cambridge 2018)
22. Do events, rather than politicians, shape the future? (Cambridge 2017)
23. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
24. 'Everyone has an opinion, but not everyone's opinion is of equal value.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2016)
25. When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, should they be directed towards the young or the old? (Cambridge 2015)
26. In times of economic hardship, should a country still be expected to provide financial and material aid to others? (Cambridge 2014)
27. 'The world would be a better place if more political leaders were women.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2013)
28. To what extent is it possible 'to make the punishment fit the crime'? (Cambridge 2013)
29. How far is increased prosperity for all a realistic goal in your society? (Cambridge 2013)
30. How far, in your society, should unpopular views be open to discussion? (Cambridge 2013)
31. 'The key criterion for good government is how well the economy is managed.' Is this a fair assessment? (Cambridge 2012)
32. Consider the view that efficient government is more important than democracy. (Cambridge 2011)

B. RI Exam Questions

1. Evaluate the effectiveness of government efforts to enhance people's quality of life in your society. (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
2. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
3. To what extent does the media today undermine rather than support democracy? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
4. To what extent should the state interfere with the private lives of its citizens? (RI 2024 Y6 Prelim)
5. 'Given the complexities of today's world, only the educated should be allowed to vote.' Do you agree? (RI 2024 Y6 TP)
6. Is having a diverse range of views important when making decisions? (RI 2024 Y6 TP)
7. Discuss the claim that modern technology has made it more difficult for political leaders to govern today. (RI 2024 Y6 TP)
8. Should governments involve themselves in matters related to religion? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
9. How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
10. Is a thriving economy the best measure of a good government? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
11. Do corporations hold more power than governments today? (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
12. 'Governments are failing the people they are supposed to serve.' Discuss. (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
13. Should there be limits to freedom of speech in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
14. To what extent is diplomacy effective in dealing with conflicts today? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
15. 'Elections do not make a free country.' What is your view? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
16. To what extent is eradicating poverty a collective responsibility? (RI 2023 Y5 CT)
17. To what extent is meritocracy an effective way to enhance social mobility in your society? (RI 2023 Y5 CT)
18. 'Small countries are helpless in shaping global politics.' Do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelim)
19. Is conflict inevitable in today's volatile world? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelim)
20. To what extent is meritocracy in your society still desirable? (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)

21. 'The key to good governance is in staying accountable to the people.' How far do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 CT)
22. 'In today's digital age, freedom of expression works better in theory than in practice.' To what extent is this true? (RI 2022 Y6 CT)
23. To what extent are the young truly concerned about politics? (RI 2022 Y6 CT)
24. 'State censorship of the media is no longer necessary today.' What is your view? (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
25. Should individual rights and freedom be protected at all costs? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelim)
26. How far do you agree that good governance is key to the protection of the environment? (2021 Y6 Prelim)
27. Should the state intervene in matters relating to one's body? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelim)
28. Should environmental sustainability be given greater priority in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 CT)
29. To what extent should politicians have a say in scientific research? (RI 2021 Y6 CT)
30. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 CT)
31. 'We are less free than before.' How far do you agree with this view of modern society? (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
32. 'It is harder than ever for voters to make the right choices in elections today.' Discuss. (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
33. 'People, rather than the government, should be responsible for their own well-being.' Comment. (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
34. To what extent is health seen as a personal responsibility in your society? (RI 2021 Y5 Promo)
35. 'Race has no place in politics today.' How far do you agree? (RI 2020 Y6 Prelim)
36. To what extent do young people have a significant voice in political affairs? (RI 2020 Y6 Timed Practice)
37. 'Freedom of speech is key to building a strong democracy.' To what extent is this true? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
38. Do those who challenge the status quo have a place in your society? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
39. Consider the view that individuals, not the state, are in the best position to determine their overall well-being. (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
40. 'There is no point in resisting surveillance.' Do you agree? (RI Y5 Promo 2020)
41. 'When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, the poor should be given the highest priority.' What is your view? (RI Y5 Promo 2020)
42. Assess the view that your society is not doing enough to eradicate prejudice. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
43. To what extent is poverty the fault of the individual? (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
44. To what extent is progress achieved at the expense of our welfare? (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
45. Consider the argument that it is impossible to solve climate change in today's world. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
46. How far should governments interfere in the way individuals organise their lives? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
47. How far is punishment an effective solution to crime? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
48. 'Politics is often more concerned with power than with people.' Is this a fair statement? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
49. In the light of increasing security threats, should countries still embrace the notion of a borderless world? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
50. Consider the notion that reaching a consensus is an ideal way to govern. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
51. Assess the view that government regulation is the best way to achieve a trustworthy media. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
52. Should the responsibility of taking care of the elderly fall solely on the government? (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)

53. 'Now more than ever, the arts should be subject to government censorship.' Comment. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
54. Should politicians be expected to always tell the truth? (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
55. 'Surveillance of the people is a necessary evil.' Discuss. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelim)
56. Assess the view that international organisations are mostly ineffective. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelim)
57. 'Young people celebrate the wrong heroes.' How far is this true in your society today? (RI 2018 Y6 Prelim)
58. Should a government always listen to its people? (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
59. 'The provision of financial or material aid to countries in need does more harm than good.' Discuss. (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
60. Is it ever justifiable for people in society to make decisions for those who are unable to do so? (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
61. Do you agree that efforts by the government to ensure greater inclusion in your society have done more harm than good? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
62. In times of economic hardship, should a government be expected to provide financial support to the arts? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
63. Should young people take a more active interest in politics, even when it is not directly relevant to their lives? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
64. Discuss the claim that the digital age has made it more challenging for political leaders to govern today. (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
65. To what extent should the state have a right to intervene in the decisions of individuals when it comes to matters of health? Discuss this with regard to your society. (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
66. Do monarchies still serve any purpose in today's society? (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
67. Should refugees be viewed as a burden in modern society? (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
68. 'We should abolish state funding for the Arts.' How far do you agree that this should be the case for your society? (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
69. Consider the effectiveness of social activism in your society. (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
70. 'Political leaders have no right to impose their own values and beliefs on the people they govern.' Do you agree? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
71. 'A nation that simply complains.' Is this a fair comment about your society? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
72. 'A country should take care of its own interests before others.' What is your view? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
73. Evaluate the claim that too much has been done for the elderly in your society. (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
74. 'Business should have no place in politics.' Do you agree? (RI 2017 Y6 Prelim)
75. Is it ever justified to sacrifice human rights for a country's progress? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
76. In times of economic hardship, is it acceptable for a government to spend on weapons and its armed forces? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
77. 'At a time when the world needs capable leadership, many politicians do not seem to be up to the job.' Do you agree? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
78. How far should the State be allowed to restrict individual rights when security is at stake? (RI 2017 Y5 CT1)
79. Is it reasonable to expect politicians to be completely honest? (RI 2016 Y6 CT2)
80. In the world today, a nation's economic success is nothing more than a case of luck.' Is this a fair assessment? (RI 2016 Y6 CT2)
81. 'A good government should always put the interests of the majority first'. Discuss. (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
82. How far do you agree that freedom has been destructive for society? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
83. Should your government do less for its people? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
84. 'The State has no place in the private lives of its citizens.' Do you agree? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelim)
85. How far is your society prepared for the challenges that diversity brings? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelim)
86. Is it ever justifiable to execute criminals? (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)

87. 'Democracy is essential for a country to become a developed nation.' Do you agree? (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
88. 'Laws are the most effective way to combat prejudice and discrimination.' How far would you accept this view? (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
89. 'Freedom of speech should be a privilege, not an entitlement.' How far would you agree with this statement? (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
90. 'It is better to be an entertainment celebrity than a politician today.' What is your view? (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
91. 'The key to a nation's success lies in economic growth.' Discuss. (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)
92. 'Ours is a country of divided people.' Is this a valid comment on your society? (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)
93. 'Personal privacy and national security cannot co-exist.' Comment. (RI 2015 Y5 CT1)
94. Should society pay more attention to the needs of criminals? (RI 2015 Y5 CT1)
95. 'Censorship is both harmful and futile in today's society.' Comment. (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
96. 'Pragmatism is more important than morality.' Discuss this with reference to politics. (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
97. To what extent have people given up their freedom for comfort? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
98. 'The environment should be the responsibility of the individual, not the government.' Comment. (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
99. 'It is better to obey than to question.' How far is this true of your society? (RI 2014 Y6 CT2)
100. Should governments prioritise social welfare above overall economic growth? (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)
101. How far is the media responsible for promoting democracy in your society? (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)
102. 'For the sake of security, a nation has every right to monitor its citizens.' Discuss. (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)
103. Consider the view that people in your society have unrealistic expectations of their government. (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
104. To what extent is healthy debate encouraged in your society? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
105. To what extent has the political climate in your society changed for the better? (RI 2013 Y6 Prelim)
106. Should the state involve itself in matters relating to the family? (RI 2013 Y5 Promo)
107. 'Democracy means more than having the right to vote.' Discuss. (RI 2013 Y6 CT 2)
108. What priorities would you set for government expenditure in your country and why? (RI 2013 Y6 CT 2)
109. 'An educated people can be easily governed.' Is this a valid statement? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelim)
110. 'Women are not suited for politics.' To what extent is this true? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelim)
111. Do you agree that the tools of social media have reinvented social activism? (RI 2012 Y6 CT2)
112. Do you think that your society will benefit from more freedom? (RI 2012 Y6 CT1)
113. 'Fine in principle but failure in practice.' How far do you agree with this assessment of democracy? (RI 2012 Y6 CT1)

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 1: Demophobic society - Singapore's allergy to the D-word weakens us

EU 1 & 3

Adapted from Chapter 7 of "Singapore Incomplete" | Cherian George | 2017

The following 2 readings will help you to:

- Understand what the tenets of "liberal democracy" are
- Understand why Singapore's style of governance is often labelled as "illiberal democracy"
- Examine arguments criticising and supporting Singapore's style of governance

The strangest exchange I've had with the Singapore government occurred early in my second career as an academic. The Straits Times had just published my op-ed piece trying to explain the rationale behind opposition politician Chee Soon Juan's civil disobedience campaign. In reply, the Prime Minister's Office questioned whether I was being non-partisan, and basically accused me of using my
5 academic position to disguise myself as a dispassionate observer.

The PMO's letter brandished a few lines from the 8,000-word academic paper on which my ST article was based – lines, it said, that revealed my "true intention": That I wanted to subvert an elected government, perhaps? Not quite. The supposedly self-incriminating lines showed – voila! – that I was in favour of democracy for Singapore.

- 10 Let's consider the irony here. The five white stars on Singapore's flag represent the nation's core principles, one of which is democracy. Every school day, children stand before the flag and promise, hand on heart, "to build a democratic society". I was basically being accused of trying to fulfil our national pledge.

- 15 The irony of the government's demophobia goes deeper. The People's Action Party has been a major beneficiary of democracy. Lee Kuan Yew didn't have to go to war to come to power, like George Washington or Mao Zedong did. Our nationalists succeeded by targeting polling stations, not enemy brigades; by counting ballots, not bodies. Thanks to democracy, no PAP leader had to lose his life to win the right to rule.

- 20 Indeed, the PAP's electoral victories in recent decades have been reflective of genuine popular support. I've not seen any opinion poll, from any source, that shows approval ratings for the government lower than the PAP's share of the popular vote, which would be the case if elections were rigged.

- 25 So why does the PAP keep badmouthing democracy? Democratisation wouldn't be fatal for PAP rule as such. But it would cramp the PAP's preferred style of government. It wants maximum room to exercise discretionary power, with as few checks and balances as it can get away with. In the government's eyes, democracy looks like the ungainly, hipswaying Olympic sport of race-walking, with esoteric rules making it unnecessarily hard to progress from point A to point B, and which is treated seriously only because it came from the West and everyone's too politically correct to say, enough already.

Democracy: Not perfect, but still the best system

- 30 Democracy is about popular sovereignty, giving all adults equal rights to pick the people who get to wield state power. Lee Kuan Yew voiced misgivings about even this basic principle. Clearly, not everyone can be trusted to act for the common good, or even to make intelligent choices in their own self-interest.

35 But the democratic principle of “one person, one vote” has never been based on the fiction of uniform ability. When the American founding fathers declared as a self-evident truth that everyone is “created” equal, they meant just that: people enter the world equally endowed with certain basic rights. It is a moral statement, distinguishing democracy from systems that treat some groups as rulers by birthright while others as destined to be ruled.

40 No democrat claims adults are equally capable of making wise decisions in the public interest – this is just one of many myths that democracy’s opponents construct to make this form of government seem as absurd a sport as race-walking. Nor do democrats claim that the system always hands power to the most able or honest leaders. (Donald Trump. Enough said.)

45 What makes democracy the best political system ever devised is not that voters unfailingly choose good governments, but that it gives people a peaceful way to kick out bad ones. Democracy enables peaceful turnovers of power because of the moral legitimacy that has come to be attached to the vote. Citizens are not equal in reality, but it’s because a clean election gives equal weight to everyone’s vote that voters peacefully accept the result, even when they are on the losing side.

50 Of course, most citizens will never live up to their civic responsibilities. Popular sovereignty can also produce tyranny of the majority. Therefore, while every democratic system requires the government to be elected by the people and to act for them, each also carves out domains to be insulated from the vagaries of public opinion. In these protected spaces, decision-making is guided by core values, expert judgement and long-term concerns, not popular pressure. Courts, for example, are required to be guided by the law, not TV talking heads, opinion polls or lynch mobs. There are times when the

55 ablest people need to be given the space to do the job with minimum interference by the rest of us.

Exactly where to draw the line between public participation and managerial autonomy is something we have to work out domain by domain. When countries overdo popular participation, the result may be governmental inefficiency or, paradoxically, the rise of demagogues who hijack mass movements for their own ends. On the other hand, inadequate public accountability and voice routinely leads to

60 corruption and abuse of power.

Democracies have found that the most promising approaches lie at neither extreme. They need state institutions that are open to public scrutiny and subject to on-going checks and balances, but that are also guided by their own professional ethos and granted sufficient autonomy to get their jobs done. Yes, democracy always carries the risk of a bad government being voted in. And, yes, such a

65 government could do irreparable damage to Singapore. But if we are unusually fragile, it’s not because we’re small. It’s because our system of checks and balances is weak. No matter how strong its mandate, an elected government’s power to do harm needs to be limited by independent institutions and civil liberties.

Singapore: More mature approach needed

This is the kind of nuanced debate we should be having in Singapore, not “Democracy: Good or Bad”.

70 A detailed audit of our political system would probably show mixed results. In some areas, popular participation is being unreasonably obstructed. In particular, Singapore is a laggard – even by non-Western standards – in introducing open government reforms such as the right to information. Since the late 20th century, many countries have seen the wisdom of empowering ordinary citizens with government information on demand, thus crowdsourcing the battle against corruption and

75 inefficiency.

The government’s standard answer when we ask for more accountability is that Singaporeans get to hold it to account every five years in the voting booth. The problem, though, is that Singapore does

not pass some of the democratic tests for free and fair elections.

80 The polling process itself is as clean as one can reasonably expect. But elections are not just about what happens on polling day. Democratic choice is a process requiring certain conditions to be met on both the demand and supply sides. On the demand side, voters must be able to learn about and discuss their choices fully – which requires much more freedom of media and public assembly than we currently enjoy. On the supply side, contenders for power must not be unfairly disadvantaged long before the polls – an independent election commission is a must, particularly to prevent
85 gerrymandering. Nor should they be obstructed from fulfilling their mandates if they win – which is the effect of denying opposition MPs any say in their constituencies' government grassroots machinery.

A thorough democratic audit would also reveal some aspects of Singapore's political system that are too susceptible to populism. Due to objections from religious conservatives, the government has
90 refused to decriminalise sex between gay men or allow LGBT activists to campaign openly for their rights. This nod to conservative public opinion subverts equality, which is a foundational principle of democracy and which no group should be denied just because it's reviled by others.

Democratising Singapore isn't about importing any other country's system or values wholesale. There is no single model; advanced democracies have some features that are exemplary and others we
95 should avoid. Singapore has strengths of its own. Stable, compact, digitally connected and highly educated, Singapore has better conditions than most for deepening its democracy.

First, however, it will need to get over its instinctive defensive reaction the moment the D-word is brought up. That reflex may have something to do with decades of Western haranguing. Western politicians, journalists and activists kept trying to recreate Singapore in their own image.

100 Lee Kuan Yew was not the sort to play the role of humble student, so he went on the offensive, pointing out the dysfunctions in Western democracies. Other PAP politicians and diplomats followed his lead. After decades of practice, it's little wonder the PAP team got very comfortable with speaking up against democracy. Over time, the habit became national dogma.

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 2: A defence of Singapore-style democracy

EU 1-3

Adapted from A defence of Singapore-style democracy | Daniel Chai and Gregory Koh | Consensus | 15 April 2017

Singapore's government, led by the People's Action Party (PAP), rejects Western style liberal democracy in favour of its own form of democracy. While Singapore's performance on the Economist Intelligence Unit's (EIU) democracy index has improved over the past decade, moving from a 'hybrid regime' to a 'flawed democracy', Singapore still draws international criticism for the state of its democracy.

Not a liberal democracy?

Singapore's Parliament is modelled after the UK Westminster model, with local variations. We are a representative democracy with a government elected through regular election cycles. In this respect, Singapore can be considered a democracy.

Singapore, however, does not adhere to the standards of Western liberal democracy¹, leading to the EIU's classification of a 'flawed democracy'. 'Flawed democracies' have fair and free elections and protections for basic civil liberties, but may have issues in other democratic aspects such as low press freedoms, an underdeveloped political culture, low levels of political participation, and issues concerning the functioning and transparency of governance.

Perhaps a more accurate description of Singapore's government would be the term 'illiberal democracy' – a system of governance whereby elections take place, but citizens are cut off from the knowledge about the activities of those who exercise real power because of the lack of civil liberties.

Singapore's take on Western democracy

In interviews with American journalist Fareed Zakaria, Lee Kuan Yew expressed his admiration for American inventiveness and creativity. He also liked the openness between people across all walks of society and the transparency and accountability of the government.

Lee, however, criticised the 'breakdown of civil society' in Western nations due to the propagation of liberal democratic ideas and the affirmation of the individuals' rights to behave or misbehave as they pleased at the expense of an orderly society.

To this end, Lee said, "Democratic procedures have no intrinsic value. What matters is good government." He believed that the government's primary duty is to create a "stable and orderly society" where "people are well cared for, their food, housing, employment, health".

This pragmatic ideology was echoed by other Singaporean politicians such as former Foreign Affairs Minister, George Yeo, who said in 1992 that "the test of democracy is not how we measure up against someone else's theoretical construct, but what works for us given our history and circumstances. It is a Darwinian test. What succeeds will endure."

Criticism of Singaporean-style democracy

Singapore's form of 'illiberal' democracy is a balance between Western style liberal democracy and Singapore's pragmatic needs, aimed at the preservation of Singapore as a state above all else.

¹ According to the philosopher John Rawls, characteristics of a liberal democracy include fair and free elections between multiple distinct political parties, the rule of law in everyday life as part of an open society, and the protection of human and civil rights and civil liberties, as well as the freedom religious belief and political association for all people.

35 While Singapore ranks well in many categories the World Bank's measures for 'good governance' in areas such as basic safety and security provided by law, Singapore's one-party government is often criticised for its curtailment of the socio-political spaces accorded to civil liberties and other forms of political association and pluralism beyond that of the government.

40 Other criticisms of Singapore's democracy include the curtailment of the freedom of expression, assembly and association through broad legal provisions on security, public order, morality and racial and religious harmony through a slew of legal statutes such as the sedition and the Internal Security Act (ISA). The Singapore government has also been criticised for its use of strong defamation laws and the offence of "scandalising the judiciary". One prominent example of the use of these laws was against blogger Roy Ngerng, who was sued by Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong for making defamatory remarks about Lee and the Central Provident Fund (CPF) policy.

45 Despite these laws, Singaporeans are increasingly turning to social media to voice their opinions on political matters through numerous online blogs and alternative news platforms; though as the Roy Ngerng case demonstrates, there are still stringent guidelines to be followed.

50 Singapore receives human-rights-related criticisms as well. Human Rights Watch, an international non-governmental organisation, has criticised Singapore on several issues including the use of corporal punishment, including caning (deemed as torture), the death penalty, and the restriction of the civil rights of homosexuals under Section 377A of the penal code, which criminalizes sexual acts between homosexual men.

The Singapore government maintains that these laws and punishments are put in place because Singapore values its order and social harmony over ideological and intangible ideologies.

Singapore's reasons for rejecting Western-style democracy

55 Considering Singapore's early history as well as its vulnerable position in the world, Singapore has strong reasons to adopt a realistic and pragmatic approach to governance, and prevent any negative consequences of Western style liberal democracy from hindering her progress and survival.

Singapore's reasons for its rejection of Western-style democracy can be divided into three main areas: multiculturalism, security, and economic development.

(i) Multiculturalism

60 Singapore is home to a diverse mix of cultures and races with a 70% Chinese majority, as well as Indian and Malay minorities. This diverse mix has the potential for racial tension and conflict, as evidenced in the years surrounding Singapore's independence. As a result, it is imperative that the Singapore government takes a tough stance on the freedom of expression, especially regarding sensitive racial remarks.

65 A recent example of the use of the Racial and Religious Harmony Act was against the authors of online alternative news site 'The Real Singapore' for attempting to sow discord amongst the different communities when they published a false article claiming that an incident had occurred between the police and some members of the public during a Thaipusam procession sparked by a Filipino family's complaint that the drums played during the procession upset their child.

70 On the other hand, there have been incidences of racial and religious strife in European countries that champion Western liberal ideals and protect the freedom of expression. Prominent examples include

the controversy surrounding the Danish Prophet Mohammed cartoons, and the Charlie Hebdo incident.

These examples give Singapore's government a strong reason to reject elements of Western style liberal democracy in the interest of preserving social harmony and stability among Singapore's multicultural populace.

(ii) Security

Being a small state with a Chinese majority, Singapore is placed in a vulnerable position in the Southeast Malay peninsula. It is therefore imperative that Singapore maintain strong bilateral ties with its surrounding neighbours and respect their cultural and religious sensitivities.

To this end, restrictions on the freedom of expression and the press need to be put in place to prevent the press or social media from being irresponsible in the way it reports on Singapore's relationship with its neighbours such as Malaysia and Indonesia. As these countries represent some of Singapore's biggest trading partners, Singapore has an economic incentive to maintain positive relationships with these countries.

Singapore's small size and population make Singapore vulnerable to external threats. In a symposium by RSIS' Studies in Inter-Religious Relations in Plural Societies Programme, Law and Home Affairs Minister K Shanmugam highlighted the serious threat of ISIS and growing extremism in the region, stressing on the need for the continued limits on the freedom of speech, as any offensive statement or post originating here may provoke retaliation, compromising Singapore's safety.

(iii) Economic development

Singapore's economic growth has been attributed to its societal and economic stability in comparison to its regional neighbours such as Malaysia, and Thailand. In Malaysia, anti-government protests calling for the resignation of Prime Minister Najib Razak in late 2015 along with divisions within the ruling party has fuelled Malaysia's deteriorating economy. In a similar vein, frequent clashes between the 'Red Shirts' and 'Yellow Shirts' in Thailand has hampered Thailand's economic growth.

Given Singapore's lack of natural resources, Singapore relies on heavily entrepot trade and foreign investment for survival. Any instability within Singapore would cause Singapore to lose its key economic advantage over its neighbours if investors pull out of the country, and this will in turn threaten its survival. In terms of balancing between centralising enough power to deal with external threats and maximize economic opportunities against promoting individual liberty in order to foster creativity and individual expression, it is understandable that Singapore's government prioritises stability and growth over Western liberal democratic values.

Conclusion

While Singapore can be classified as a democracy insofar as it allows for religious freedom (to a large extent), and having free, fair and regular elections. Singapore does not fit the standards of Western style liberal democracy as the electoral process favours the ruling party, and there are still restrictions on the freedom of expression as well as the press.

However, Singapore has strong reasons for doing so. The Singapore government rejects Western style liberal democracy to the extent that it threatens Singapore's survival, citing economic development and survival, security and multiculturalism as reasons for doing so. With these issues at stake, it is unlikely that Singapore will ever meet the standards of Western style liberal democracy – and that need not necessarily be a bad thing.

For discussion/reflection:

1. George argues that due to Singapore being '[s]table, compact, digitally connected and highly educated' (Reading 1, lines 95-96), she 'has better conditions than most for deepening its democracy' (line 96). In what ways might the 'conditions' cited actually be arguments against the adopting of a more democratic style of governance?
2. Chai and Koh highlight a 'pragmatic ideology' (Reading 2, line 26) as the reason behind Singapore's style of government, while George asserts that the real motivation is having 'as few checks and balances as it can get away with' (Reading 1, line 25). Which depiction of the government's style and intentions do you find more representative and why?
3. Chai and Koh give 'strong reasons [for Singapore] to adopt a realistic and pragmatic approach to governance' (Reading 2, line 55), which they identify as being 'Singapore's early history as well as its vulnerable position in the world' (line 54). Attempt to refute this argument with your own line of reasoning.
4. Based on your understanding of both readings, consider whether government control and the people's agency are necessarily mutually exclusive. Is it possible that greater agency might reinforce the government's ability to govern, and vice versa?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'Democracy is the perfect form of government.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. 'In a free society, there should be no restrictions on freedom of speech.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2020)
3. How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
4. 'Governments are failing the people they are supposed to serve.' Discuss. (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
5. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 Common Test)
6. 'Freedom of speech is key to building a strong democracy.' To what extent is this true? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
7. Consider the notion that reaching a consensus is an ideal way to govern. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 3: Singapore needs loving critics

EU 1-3

Adapted from Pritam Singh seconds Tommy Koh's sentiment that Singapore needs loving critics | The Independent | Jewel Stolarchuk | 12 June 2020

This reading will help you to understand:

- Why there is a need for more diverse voices in Singapore's political discourse, particularly voices that provide constructive criticism
- That a political environment that generates a 'contestation of ideas', rather than perspectives that merely mirror the dominant narratives, is likely to strengthen Singapore's democracy
- That normalising constructive discourse can lead to positive political outcomes, such as greater citizen engagement, and empowerment of other key political stakeholders

The WP chief urged the Government not to pick on these loving critics and alluded to an incident in Parliament last year, when Education Minister Ong Ye Kung lambasted local playwright Alfian Sa'at and accused him of trying to sow discord in Singapore.

5 Workers' Party (WP) secretary-general Pritam Singh seconded veteran diplomat Tommy Koh's sentiment that Singapore needs 'loving critics', during his parliamentary speech on the Fortitude Budget. Dr Koh, a distinguished diplomat who currently serves as Ambassador-At-Large at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Professor of Law at the National University of Singapore, urged the Government to welcome criticism from critics who love Singapore, last year.

10 Asserting that "the contestation of ideas is a necessary part of democracy" and that the Government should not "blacklist intellectuals, artists, writers because they criticise the Government or hold dissenting views, Dr Koh said: "Singapore will languish if our lovers are uncritical and our critics are unloving. What Singapore needs is not sycophants but loving critics and critical lovers."

15 Echoing Dr Koh's views, Mr Pritam told Parliament that Singapore "should count ourselves fortunate that we have citizens who are the loving critics amongst us." The opposition chief also urged the Government against picking on these loving critics and alluded to an incident in Parliament last year, when Education Minister Ong Ye Kung lambasted local playwright Alfian Sa'at and accused him of trying to sow discord in Singapore.

20 Singling out Mr Alfian for his role in a cancelled Yale-NUS module on dialogue and dissent, Mr Ong cherry-picked quotes from a poem Mr Alfian wrote in 1998 and insinuated that the poet hated Singapore and is unpatriotic.

Dr Tommy Koh was among the dozens of influential figures who threw their weight behind Mr Alfian in the aftermath of Mr Ong's aggressive parliamentary speech. Dr Koh wrote on Facebook, then: "We should not demonise Alfian Sa'at. He is one of our most talented playwrights. I regard him as a loving critic of Singapore. He is not anti-Singapore."

25 Mr Pritam backed Dr Koh's views in Parliament. Urging the Government to give space for contrarian views and perspectives, he said: "With many corporates and big businesses already perceived to be over-represented in our political ecology be it through the grassroots or through their association in private-public national level committees, Government needs to consider how it can become a better arbiter between differing views, to give and encourage more space to our youth, NGOs unlinked to GLCs and trade-unions, and the people sector to voice to their contrarian views and perspectives. This

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should be done, while retaining a laser-like focus on fact-based conversations that portend a progressive future all Singaporeans can endeavour towards.

35 Referring to the Ong-Alfian episode, he said: “In my view Mr Speaker, we should count ourselves fortunate that we have citizens who are the loving critics amongst us, some of whom have been questioned in this very House in this term of government. Members would recall one citizen’s poems were nit-picked with a view to cast wholly negative aspersions on his character, even though that individual was not present in the House to defend himself.”

40 Mr Pritam pointed out that the public look to people with influence on how to debate with those they disagree with and said that dealing with differences of opinion with a binary lens would make Singapore an ordinary society in the post-COVID world. He said: “Mr Speaker, when any leader or person of influence engages in what will be interpreted as dog-whistling, it sets the tone for how members of the public debate with those whose views they disagree with. If binary, black and white perspectives are the shape of how we as a society deal with differences after COVID-19, Singapore will become an ordinary society, no different from many around in the world.”

45 Urging the Government to see that citizens criticise because they love the nation, Mr Pritam added: “Nobody expects the Government to willy-nilly change its decision at the first sign of pressure and agree with a critic. Singaporeans do recognise the multitude of perspectives the Government has to take cognisance of, but it is important to recognise that citizens criticise and organise because they care.”

50 Calling on the authorities to consider opening more avenues for constructive discourse, Mr Singh urged the Government to place more faith in Singaporeans and encourage greater participation from citizens as Singapore traverses the post-COVID world: “Moving forward Government should look at opening more avenues like Parliament for citizen engagement, greater data-sharing and empower other institutions like our think-tanks and the mainstream media to give alternate perspectives more voice and even provide platforms piloting change on a small scale.”

“As we traverse the post-COVID-19 VUCA – volatile, uncertain, complex, ambiguous – world, we need to place more faith and promote even greater participation from Singaporeans than ever before.”

For discussion/reflection:

1. How does the author define the term ‘loving critics’, and what role do they play in promoting open dialogue and constructive criticism in society?
2. According to Mr Pritam Singh, why is it important for ‘people with influence’ (line 38) to not deal ‘with differences of opinion with a binary lens’ (line 39)?
3. According to Mr Pritam Singh, what are some of the benefits of having a culture of constructive criticism in Singapore? Apart from those listed, what other benefits can you think of?
4. What do you think are the potential risks and challenges associated with being a ‘loving critic’ in Singapore?
5. What might be the trade-offs involved in having a political culture where there is free and open criticism of the establishment or government? Do you think the same trade-offs, when applied to the earlier years of Singapore’s independence, are different? How are they different?
6. How does the main perspective on constructive criticism and public discourse compare with the political climate in other countries, and what do you think can Singapore learn from other countries’ experiences?

Related past-year Cambridge and RI essay questions:

1. 'In a free society, there should be no restrictions on freedom of speech.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'Everyone has an opinion, but not everyone's opinion is of equal value.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2016)
3. How far, in your society, should unpopular views be open to discussion? (Cambridge 2013)
4. Consider the view that efficient government is more important than democracy. (Cambridge 2011)
5. Should there be limits to freedom of speech in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
6. 'Elections do not make a free country.' What is your view? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
7. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 Common Test)
8. Do those who challenge the status quo have a place in your society? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 4: Leader of the Opposition: A turning point but also a 'double-edged sword' **EU 1 & 3**

Adapted from Leader of the Opposition: A turning point, Channel News Asia | Chew Hui Min | 29 July 2020

This reading will help you to understand:

- The value of a creditable alternative to the political incumbent in a democratic system, which could, in theory, give rise to a greater diversity of perspectives
- Concessions made by the PAP, as the political incumbent, to allow for a more prominent opposition presence in the Parliament, in the Workers Party
- In what ways the new Leader of the Opposition position is still limited in terms of the actual power to enact significant changes

On Tuesday, it was announced that as the Leader of the Opposition, Workers' Party (WP) chief Pritam Singh will get additional parliamentary privileges, resources to hire more legislative assistants and double the pay of a Member of Parliament (MP). Accepting the position, Mr Singh said: "The Leader of the Opposition appointment carries with it many additional responsibilities that I will have to shoulder. The road ahead will not be easy, but I thank Singaporeans for their support and encouragement."

Political observer Felix Tan called the new office a "good start", and said that with more resources and information for the opposition, this could push debate in Parliament to a different level. "After more than 50 years, Singapore's political landscape is finally entering a new phase. The recognition of the role the opposition would surely put the Workers' Party in good stead," said the associate lecturer in international relations at SIM Global Education. "So, now, the ball is in the WP's court to produce and introduce feasible policies."

"Key turning point"

Authorities said on Tuesday that the Leader of the Opposition will receive allowances to hire up to three additional legislative assistants on top of the allowances all MPs receive for one legislative assistant and one secretarial assistant. In addition to the government data or information available to other MPs, Mr Singh will receive confidential briefings by the Government on "select matters of national security and external relations, and in the event of a national crisis or emergency". In Parliament, he will generally be given the right of first response among MPs and to ask the lead question to the ministers. He will also be given more time to speak, equivalent to political officeholders. His duties include leading the opposition in presenting alternative views in parliamentary debates on policies, Bills and motions, and leading the scrutiny of the Government's positions and actions in Parliament.

Mr Leonard Lim, country director for Singapore for government affairs consultancy Vriens & Partners, said that this was a "key turning point in Singapore's political landscape. This entrenches the role of the opposition in Singapore's Parliament, confers a higher level of authority on Pritam within the House, and guarantees more air-time for a greater diversity of views to be aired in Parliament," he said.

However, the appointment does not change Singapore's political system in form and in substance, said political analyst Eugene Tan, an associate professor of law at the Singapore Management University. "The LO (Leader of the Opposition) office is not designed to create a new parliamentary system but to reinforce the existing one by formally recognising and institutionalising the role of a responsible, credible, and loyal opposition in Singapore's constitutional system of government," he said. "It is about furthering the goal of a collaborative system of governance for the benefit of Singapore and Singaporeans." Where change may take place would be in Singaporeans' understanding, expectations and demands of the opposition, he added.

A shadow cabinet?

Analysts pointed out that the move needs to be seen in the Singapore context where the number of opposition MPs remains small. There will be 10 elected Workers' Party MPs and two Non-Constituency MPs from the Progress Singapore Party (PSP) in the 14th Parliament, a total of 12. The People's Action Party (PAP) retains its super majority with 83, or nearly 90 per cent, of the 93 parliamentary seats. In countries with similar parliamentary systems, the Leader of the Opposition leads a shadow Cabinet with senior members of the opposition who mirror the role of political office holders, and provide the semblance of an alternative government-in-waiting. But this may not be feasible in Singapore, where there are 15 ministries and its Cabinet has 20 ministers, including those under the Prime Minister's Office.

"Singapore is going to be different from what you have in other countries because usually the idea is that the leader would be the head of the shadow government," said Dr Gillian Koh, deputy director for research at the Institute of Policy Studies. "In this case ... one could argue that 12 might be enough to man all the key portfolios of government, so it is within Pritam Singh's prerogative to decide if he would like to organise the opposition parliamentarians into a form of shadow government. It is entirely within his prerogative but also his political imagination to work within what is now possible." Mr Singh could divide the need to present alternative views in Parliament according to portfolios, Dr Koh added, and this would be moving towards "a rudimentary form of shadow government".

Mr Lim of Vriens & Partners said that expecting a shadow government was premature given the small number of opposition MPs, and while it may be possible in the future, it is unlikely to occur during this term of government. It is not helpful to juxtapose the office against that in other jurisdictions as the state of the opposition in Singapore is "vastly different" compared with the established democracies, said Assoc Prof Tan. "Ours is still very much a one-party dominant system whereas the established democracies are either longstanding two-party or multi-party systems," he said.

On whether the appointment of a leader of the opposition is a step towards a two-party system, Dr Koh said it was not necessarily so. "The way to a two-party system is through the ballot box. It has to be about the numbers and the popular will," she said. "It remains to be seen whether WP wishes to build itself up and whether it's got the resources and aspiration to present an alternative government. It remains to be seen whether that is their strategy or not, they may choose not to, they may choose to. And this is something that can evolve over the next four to five years."

Managing political change

The Prime Minister has said that the formalisation of the Leader of the Opposition was a recognition that while Singaporeans want a PAP Government, they also want a diversity of voices and alternative views in Parliament. "I look forward to more vigorous but constructive debates in Parliament. I hope our colleagues across the aisle will step up to play their role of a responsible and loyal opposition," said Mr Lee at the swearing-in ceremony of political office holders on Monday. "Their duty is not merely to raise criticisms and ask questions of the Government, necessary as these functions are. But also, more importantly, to put forward serious policy alternatives to be scrutinised and debated."

The new position may be a way to "help the Government to manage the pace of political change in Singapore," Assoc Prof Tan said. Government Parliamentary Committees (GPCs) "[r]emaining as they are - as a makeshift internal opposition within the government - will not be feasible," he said. "They were conceived at a time when opposition was much weaker. Today, the idea of the PAP backbenchers functioning as an ersatz opposition is seen as an inherent contradiction that will not work at all."

Dr Koh said that for the detractors who think that this is a state with no opposition and no contestation, it is a way to shift and institutionalise the role of the political opposition in Parliament. "It is a representation of

75 the fact that we do have a contestable system. The potential is there but the popular will isn't, nor did the parties, any party in GE2020 argue to be an alternative government," she said. Mr Lim said that the PAP would also benefit from a richer buffet of ideas and greater scrutiny of policies. "Singapore and Singaporeans will be the ultimate winners through policies that have gone through a much more rigorous level of scrutiny before being passed and implemented," he said.

"Double-edged sword" for opposition

80 However, this development can be a "double-edged sword" for the WP and the opposition in general, Assoc Prof Tan said. "If the LO office does result in the public having higher expectations of the opposition, that is a good outcome but that is unlikely to materialise in the term of the new Parliament," he said. "The resource disparity between the PAP Government and the opposition remain significant." He said that if done well, the office would be a credit to the WP and the opposition, showing what they are capable of and being able to take on greater responsibilities, but if done poorly, then the public may see the current limitations of the opposition.

Mr Lim said that a good performance by Mr Singh will burnish the WP's brand name and improve the robustness of debate in Parliament. "If Pritam performs well, we could see further enhancement of the WP brand as a rational opposition party with good alternative ideas rather than just one that 'checks' the PAP's every move. This would lead to positive knock-on effects in terms of volunteer recruitment and ground awareness for WP."

Reflections questions are found at the end of Reading 5.

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 5: WP's swift refusal of LO role signals unity behind Pritam Singh, say analysts EU 1, 4 & 7

Ng Wei Kai | The Straits Times | 21 January 2026

This reading will help you to understand:

- The value of a creditable alternative to the political incumbent in a democratic system, which could, in theory, give rise to a greater diversity of perspectives
- In what ways the new Leader of the Opposition position is still limited in terms of the actual power to enact significant changes
- The Workers' Party's decision following Pritam Singh's trial reflected ongoing support for him and how the party weighed the cost of taking the role of Leader of the Opposition

The Workers' Party declining Prime Minister Lawrence Wong's invitation to nominate another MP as Leader of the Opposition shows it has closed ranks around its chief Pritam Singh, said analysts.

5 The speed of the decision – coming less than a week after PM Wong removed Mr Singh from the post on Jan 15 – also reflects party unity and that it is "clear-cut" to the WP that the costs of taking the role outweigh the benefits, they said.

The opposition party had on Jan 21 said it is "unable to accept" PM Wong's invitation, and it takes the view that the leader of the largest opposition party in Parliament is the leader of the Opposition.

The Prime Minister's Office said in response that the Government accepts the WP's decision and that the office will remain vacant until the party chooses to nominate someone.

10 Independent political observer Felix Tan said the WP's decision was "hardly surprising" as it reinforces the party's MPs' ongoing support for Mr Singh. On Jan 14, all 11 WP MPs present dissented on a motion in Parliament that stated Mr Singh was unsuitable for the role. The House eventually voted to agree that he was unsuitable.

15 Nominating another MP as LO while keeping Mr Singh as party chief could also create factions within the party, said Dr Mustafa Izzuddin, a senior international affairs analyst at Solaris Strategies Singapore. Agreeing, Dr Tan said the decision avoids turning the LO role into a source of internal rivalry.

20 The move is also a public signal that the party has managed to reach a decision quickly, even before internal party processes on Mr Singh conclude, said Institute of Policy Studies (IPS) senior research fellow Teo Kay Key.

It shows that there are "no compelling reasons for WP to accept the PM's invitation", said Singapore Management University law don Eugene Tan. "That it was a clear-cut case for them." It also "gives us an indication that Pritam Singh will continue as secretary-general", he added.

25 The party formed a disciplinary panel in January to investigate if Mr Singh contravened the party's Constitution following his convictions for lying to a parliamentary committee. The WP has said this will take about three months.

The trade-off for the WP in not nominating an LO is that it may forgo certain procedural and symbolic institutional advantages that come with the LO position, such as the right of first response in Parliament and the additional visibility, Dr Felix Tan noted.

30 Declining PM Wong's offer is also a comment from the opposition party about the viability of the role in its current form, and a critique on his decision to remove Mr Singh from it, analysts said.

IPS senior research fellow Gillian Koh said the WP has raised the issue of the status of the scheme to the detriment of the PAP and PM Wong.

35 The WP's decision also reminds the general public about the reason for Mr Singh's removal as LO – which could win sympathy for the party, or be to its detriment.

"Citizens want fair play especially where there is large imbalance in power between the dominant (party) and the rest, and the burden seems to rest on the PAP to prove that it has not overplayed its hand against the weak," she said.

40 This is why the WP's trump card is still to "play the victim in this long-running saga", she added.

"By not providing a nominee for LO, with its arguments about foreign systems of LO, it reminds citizens of this situation."

In its Jan 21 statement declining the role, the WP said the appointment is conventionally extended to the leader of the largest opposition party in Parliament, or decided by the opposition party in question.

45 The party cited other Westminster parliamentary systems where the title of the LO is established by law and "is not the prerogative or choice of the government of the day or the prime minister".

The party's refusal of PM Wong's invitation could also prompt more discussion on the role and what it means for Singapore, Dr Teo said. "It would also raise questions on whether it is a relevant position in its current form, and what the LO should be entitled to in that position."

- 50 If the position is established by law, there would likely be more fixed rules on the criteria for who is a suitable LO, as well as more definitive regulations on the LO's entitlements and expected contributions, she noted.

Even without a formal LO, the WP remains the largest and only opposition party in Parliament with 12 MPs, observers said.

- 55 It is in a similar position to before Mr Singh was first officially appointed to the role by then Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong after the 2020 General Election, Dr Felix Tan said.

"Nothing of the structure of power has changed by any of these developments over the past weeks," Dr Koh said.

- 60 Electorally, it is still early in the cycle, Dr Mustafa noted, and other issues may take precedence in voters' minds by the next polls. How the lack of an LO will play out in the House is still in question – and a big test is on the horizon.

Singapore is headed into the Budget season, Dr Koh noted. PM Wong is scheduled to deliver the Budget on Feb 12, following which MPs will debate the Government's spending for the year.

- 65 It remains to be seen if in actual practice, the WP's role is diminished in any way by not having an LO and its privileges of the first right of response and extended speaking time, she said.

For discussion/reflection:

1. In reading 4, political observer Felix Tan characterised the appointment of a Leader of the Opposition the 'entering [of] a new phase' (line 8). In your own words, explain what this 'new phase' represents/is, and suggest reasons why the new appointment seems indicative of such a phase (other than it being a brand new position)
2. Carry out some research of your own and identify previous instances whereby concessions have been made by the incumbent government that similarly appeared to weaken their political power.
3. **In Year 5**, we learned that all media, being 'constructions of reality', contain 'embedded values and points of view' (See Media Issues, EU 3). When media sources like news outlets and new media political commentary continually refer to parties like the Workers Party, Singapore Democratic Party, and Progress Singapore Party as 'the opposition', what 'embedded values and points of view' do you think is being conveyed? Are such points of view beneficial to Singapore?
4. Notwithstanding that the formation of a 'Shadow Cabinet' might be unfeasible and Singapore is still far from being a two-party system (lines 33-60), what might be the advantages and disadvantages of such a Cabinet and system, respectively?
5. Assoc Prof Tan suggested that progressively allowing a more prominent opposition in the Parliament can 'help the Government manage the pace of political change' (lines 68-69). Reflect on what he means by this.
6. What might be the advantages and disadvantages of allowing more diverse views to permeate the government to shape policy-making?
7. Based on reading 5, what are the benefits and costs of the Worker's Party declining Prime Minister Lawrence Wong's invitation to nominate another MP as Leader of the Opposition?

8. Workers' Party's refusal of PM Wong's invitation has prompted more discussion on the role and what it means for Singapore. In your opinion, do you think it is a relevant position in its current form? What should the LO be entitled to in that position?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'Democracy is the perfect form of government.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. 'Elections do not make a free country.' What is your view? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
3. 'It is harder than ever for voters to make the right choices in elections today.' Discuss. (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
5. Consider the notion that reaching a consensus is an ideal way to govern. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
6. 'Ours is a country of divided people.' Is this a valid comment on your society? (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)
7. To what extent has the political climate in your society changed for the better? (RI 2013 Y6 Prelim)
8. 'At the end of the day, government is all about teamwork and partnership.' Comment. (RI 2010 Y6 CT2)

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 6: Focus on ability, not race in political leadership

EU 1, 4 & 7

Adapted from Tharman's Presidency should be a turning point in the non-Chinese PM Conversation | Kimberly Lim | Rice Media | 14 September 2023

This reading will help you to understand:

- The shifting tension between ethnicity and race, and political leadership, as reflected by President Tharman's presidential election victory
- How and why there is increasing openness amongst the Singapore public towards having a non-Chinese occupy the foremost political position in the government
- Why the incumbent party's internal dynamics and succession planning still exert significant influence on Singapore's political landscape
- That while President Tharman's victory symbolises a right step towards a more inclusive society, issues to do with racism and discrimination remain persistent

The landslide win of President-elect Tharman Shanmugaratnam in the presidential elections has been dissected many times over. Some analysts credit his pineapple logo and 'ong lai' chant for contributing to his landslide win. Others cite the enigmatic 'Tharman effect'.

5 In any case, Mr Tharman's victory came as no surprise. Perhaps the more shocking thing was his overwhelming 70.4 percent vote share on Polling Day. That, plus the 76.16 percent vote share he got from overseas voters. The large margin indicated that even opposition supporters voted for him. His decisive victory over Ng Kok Song and Tan Kin Lian is also a good sign that Singaporeans are more than ready for a non-Chinese leader.

10 Had voting gone purely along racial lines, he might have seen a vote share of nine percent from the Indian population or 25.7 percent from racial minorities in Singapore. That obviously wasn't the case. Mr Tharman's vote share was evidence that he'd won the hearts of a large swathe of Singapore's population, a majority of which belonged to a different race than his.

15 As Mr Tharman himself mentioned in the run-up to the election, voters "look at people in totality". And he was right. His flawless track record and gravitas cemented him as the obvious choice for many. His ethnicity was hardly part of the conversation in the lead-up to polling day. In the days since his victory, though, there has been some talk about what this election showing means for the future of another important role in Singapore's administration: the PM.

Ability trumps race

20 A YouGov survey released this week underscores that. More than three in five Singaporean respondents said they were ready for a Malay or Indian to be PM. After all, since attaining self-governance in 1959, we've only had Chinese PMs: the late founding PM Lee Kuan Yew, Goh Chok Tong in 1990, and Lee Hsien Loong, our sitting PM.

25 Contrast that with the ethnicity of our presidents, which has been markedly more diverse. We've had eight past presidents (including Halimah Yacob). Only three—Wee Kim Wee, Ong Teng Cheong, and Tony Tan—are from the majority Chinese demographic. And, of course, someone had to ask DPM Heng Swee Keat about it. After all, he asserted in 2019 that the country wasn't ready for a non-Chinese PM, sparking pushback from the general public.

The DPM might have changed his tune a little since then. Reacting to Tharman's win, DPM Heng said at Forbes Global CEO conference on September 11: "I will see it as a very positive sign that the fact that he is an Indian did not stop people from electing the best person."

- 30 "Will we ever have a non-Chinese as a Prime Minister? I will say it will come one day because Singapore society is growing, maturing, and it will come one day. As to when that day will be, I cannot tell; none of us can predict the future. But I see that as a very positive sign."

- 35 But why is Mr Tharman's race framed as an issue when voters have proved that they don't particularly care what race their leaders are? As powerful as the Tharman effect is—some might even call it 'Tharmania'—we can't exactly credit the man with turning voters race-blind.

Singaporeans have already proven in the past that they don't exactly vote along racial lines. Just look at Bukit Batok SMC, where ethnic Indian candidate Murali Pillai bested ethnic Chinese candidate Chee Soon Juan in the 2016 by-election and 2020 general election. Chee's somewhat combative image might have ultimately been his downfall, but his ethnicity certainly didn't give him a free pass.

- 40 And at the very same 2019 event where Heng made those non-Chinese PM remarks, "many" in the audience raised their hands when asked if they would be happy with a non-Chinese PM, *The Straits Times* reported. After Heng's comments made headlines, some went as far as to make police reports. In the end, however, nothing came out of that as the Attorney-General's Chambers advised the police that no offence was committed.

- 45 It's worth acknowledging, however, that the shift in Singaporeans' sentiments has been gradual. A CAN-IPS study in 2022 also showed an increase in the percentage of people comfortable with a non-Chinese PM compared to 2016. The new YouGov survey indicates that younger respondents are more open to the idea of a non-Chinese PM than older respondents.

Ready and waiting

- 50 No matter how comfortable we are with a non-Chinese PM, though, the decision isn't exactly in our hands. As Nanyang Technological University Assistant Professor Walid Jumblatt asked DPM Heng back in 2019: "Is it Singapore who is not ready for a non-Chinese prime minister, or is it the PAP (People's Action Party) who is not ready for a non-Chinese prime minister?" While our presidents are generally elected (when there isn't a walkover), our PMs aren't. The ruling party chooses its leader, who is appointed to the PM role by the president.

- 55 Whether we ever have a non-Chinese PM is really up to the ruling party. With all the surveys in favour of a non-Chinese PM and Mr Tharman's popularity, though, it's entirely possible that we could see the party with a minority race leader in the future—if they're the best person for the job. Leadership and succession is a "deadly serious" matter, PM Lee said at a PAP convention a couple years back.

- 60 As for what qualities any future PAP leader should have, he said: "It's about developing a strong team and settling among themselves a *primus inter pares* – a first amongst equals, one who can bring others together and bring out the best from every member of the team."

Race issues remain

- 65 Is Singapore ready for a non-Chinese PM? The answer appears to be a resounding yes. Is there still racism in Singapore? Also yes. Even as we rally behind Mr Tharman, we shouldn't forget that the playing field is not even for minorities. As the man himself put it, "Never think that growing up as a minority is the same as growing up as a majority (race) in Singapore." Many—including his opponents—considered Mr Tharman to be the one to beat in this presidential election. But his resumé

is clearly stacked. If his track record bore a closer resemblance to his opponents, would he still have edged them out?

70 And when minorities try to speak on racial issues, anything less than “temperate and dignified” can land them in legal trouble. Going beyond issues of outright discrimination, minorities sometimes also find the onus on them to assimilate and adapt to the culture of the majority—from dealing with their language being butchered to finding their footing in Chinese-speaking spaces.

75 Even in his choice of symbol, the pineapple—a symbol of auspiciousness in Chinese culture— one has to wonder if Mr Tharman hoped to appeal to the older Chinese crowd. As for how much the non-Chinese PM issue has been discussed, it’s all just hypothetical. PM Lee’s successor is DPM Lawrence Wong. The shortest PM term so far has been Goh Chok Tong’s 13 years of service, so we’ll have to check back in a decade or two.

80 In the meantime, as Mr Tharman prepares to take office as the first minority president to win a contested presidential election, Singapore can take pride in the fact that most of us voted based on capability rather than colour.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Lim reports that former DPM Heng Swee Keat had once ‘asserted in 2019 that the country wasn’t ready for a non-Chinese PM’ (lines 25-26). If it is indeed the case that Singapore isn’t ready for a non-Chinese PM, in what ways might Singapore’s model of multiracialism² have contributed to this?
2. There seems to have been a gradual relaxation of a race-based criteria when it comes to the government’s view concerning the appointment or election of top political positions. What might be the possible reasons behind this shift?
3. The public, according to this article, seems more than ready for a move towards a less race-based mentality in selecting their top political leaders. Discuss the reasons for this shift.
4. Lim claims that ‘when minorities try to speak on racial issues, anything less than “temperate and dignified” can land them in legal trouble’ (lines 69-70), suggesting that the majority race has an easier time commenting on race. Do you agree with such a claim? Why or why not? Substantiate with examples.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘Power these days lies more with the people than the politicians.’ To what extent is this true? (Cambridge 2021)
2. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
3. ‘Political leaders have no right to impose their own values and beliefs on the people they govern.’ Do you agree? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
4. It has been said that Singapore is economically First World but socially Third World. What is your view? (RI 2011 Y6 Prelim)
5. To what extent does your country challenge the current state of affairs? (RI 2011 Y6 CT2)

² *The Singaporean government has institutionalised multiracialism as a fundamental principle of governance, which is based on separate, racialised groups with less room for the acknowledgement or formation of more complex, hybridised identities. This model has been reified in the form of the CMIO system of ethnic classification, which undergirds all sociopolitical policies and processes.*

SECTION A: SINGAPORE'S STYLE OF DEMOCRACY

Reading 7: Forward SG report lays out roadmap for a new Singapore vision

EU 1, 3-5

Grace Yeoh | Channel News Asia | 27 October 2023

This reading will help you understand:

- The evolution of the Singapore Dream towards a greater emphasis on meaning and purpose over material success
- The need to reimagine success across society to encapsulate not just a strong economy but values like fairness, inclusiveness, and solidarity
- Key shifts in the government's provision of support in education, jobs, and for families and other groups in need
- The importance of investing in a shared tomorrow, and the forging of unity and engendering of greater civic participation

More than materialism, Singaporeans now chase meaning – and the evolving Singapore Dream must be reflected in key shifts around how its citizens define success across all areas of life. This was outlined in the Forward SG report released on Friday (Oct 27), which laid out a roadmap for a new way forward for Singapore.

- 5 The Forward SG exercise, launched in June 2022, was led by Deputy Prime Minister Lawrence Wong and other fourth-generation (4G) political leaders to review and refresh Singapore's "social compact". This has been described as "the glue that holds society together, the shared understanding of our roles and responsibilities towards each other, and our shared values and aspirations as a people". The exercise brought together more than 200,000 Singaporeans over 16 months to discuss issues ranging from careers to ageing and environmental sustainability.

- 15 An area that "constantly emerged" in discussions, according to the report that spanned almost 180 pages, was how the idea of a 'good life' has evolved beyond material success. "In particular, there have been discernible shifts in our youths' mindset. When young people today talk about careers and jobs, they often express a desire for meaning and purpose in what they do, not just for good salaries. In other words, we want to embrace wider definitions of success," it noted.

- 20 The exercise also found that Singaporeans agree it is critical to have a strong and vibrant economy, as well as to uphold values of fairness, inclusiveness, stewardship, and "a shared sense of solidarity and mutual responsibility, where everyone gives back to society and helps those in need". At the same time, "hard conversations" involving different views that were encountered reinforced core principles Singapore should continue to uphold and highlighted existing approaches to be refreshed.

On the whole, the exercise found that Singaporeans want a society that is vibrant and inclusive, fair and thriving, and resilient and united.

Changes needed in education, jobs, social support

Refreshing the Singapore Dream hence requires several key shifts, spanning education, jobs and support for families and seniors, the report stated.

- 25 In education, the focus should shift from an education arms race to a mentality that strives to learn and improve throughout life. Along the same vein, this means creating diverse career pathways for Singaporeans to be the "best version of themselves" and make a difference in their own ways.

Individual responsibility should go hand in hand with "a greater sense of collective responsibility" – from providing more support for families and seniors to helping Singaporeans bounce back from setbacks with a better social support system. "Ultimately, we aim to build a stronger sense of solidarity and identity as Singaporeans ... We want every Singaporean to know and feel a stake in our shared future, while possessing a sense of obligation and responsibility to one another," the report said.

To realise this collective vision, it outlined seven key shifts required:

1. Support families through every stage of life

Making Singapore the best place to start, grow or nurture families means giving them more assurance and helping them balance work and family commitments, the report said. More support will be provided for new parents, including possible increases to paid parental leave and expanding centre-based infant care places and childcare options.

Singaporeans will get more support for mental well-being and work-life harmony, through a set of tripartite guidelines on flexible work arrangements to be released in 2024 and the national mental health and well-being strategy launched earlier this month. Increasing the affordability of early intervention, education, and care services for families with children with developmental and special educational needs will also improve support for caregivers.

2. Respect and reward every job

Addressing Singaporeans' growing desire for meaningful jobs and opportunities to develop mastery of skills, this key shift will require further reducing wage gaps for those in "hands" and "heart" jobs. The report listed professional tradespeople like electricians and plumbers, as well as many in the healthcare and aged care sectors. The government will study how it can help Institute of Technical Education graduates by defraying the costs of obtaining a diploma and possibly topping up their Central Provident Fund (CPF) when they graduate.

It will also support those who want to switch careers by using digital tools and career guidance services to provide more personalised recommendations on jobs and skills pathways. A new support scheme to help "involuntarily unemployed jobseekers" will be rolled out to help them "bounce back stronger". The government will also work with employers and industry associations to nurture local talent to become specialists and leaders in their fields, especially for top regional roles in multinational corporations.

3. Embrace learning beyond grades

Relatedly, the report highlighted the need for Singaporeans to pursue lifelong learning "beyond grades". A "significant boost" to SkillsFuture will be provided to help mature mid-career Singaporeans reskill and upskill. This includes a substantial top-up of SkillsFuture credit and support for Singaporeans to obtain another publicly funded diploma.

This shift also requires a broadened definition of merit and developing more diverse pathways, such as the move to full subject-based banding in secondary schools from next year. Cultivating a love for learning also means giving every child a good start, including paying more attention to children from lower-income families.

4. Empower those in need

Support for children from lower-income families also entails closing "early gaps" by raising preschool enrolment and attendance, the report said. Changes that will be made in this area include extending full childcare subsidies to lower-income families based on their income tier.

This key shift to empower those in need also includes working with community partners to provide additional support to empower vulnerable families to "sustain progress" in improving their life

circumstances. It will also see strengthened support for people with disabilities to pursue lifelong learning, and create more inclusive environments where they can "participate and live independently".

5. Enable seniors to age well

70 As Singapore's population continues to age, enabling seniors to age well is key, and this can be achieved through national programmes like Healthier SG and Age Well SG. The government will encourage active ageing in the community by expanding the network of active ageing centres and revamping their operations. It will also strengthen the community-based aged care system, making seniors' care journey "simpler and more seamless", the report said.

75 Seniors will also see improvements to their living environment, including more senior-friendly features and more housing options integrated with care provisions. To ensure seniors retire with "peace of mind", existing schemes like the Silver Support Scheme and Matched Retirement Savings Scheme will be enhanced. The Majulah Package, targeted at Singaporeans aged 50 and above this year, will also be introduced to boost their retirement savings.

6. Invest in a shared tomorrow

80 Singapore can deal with today's challenges while providing a strong foundation for the future by "stewarding our limited resources responsibly and sustainably" on three main fronts, the report said. These include optimising limited land and environmental resources, strengthening our food and water security, and upholding fiscal prudence and responsibility.

85 "All these will require more public resources, which come largely from tax revenues, as well as investment returns from our reserves. Difficult decisions will have to be made on how we will prioritise our spending, who pays, and how to keep our overall system fair and equitable," the report stated. "These considerations of fairness apply not just to today but also across generations. If we only think short term, we may end up short-changing the next generation, who will inherit a Singapore that is ill-prepared for the challenges of the future."
90

7. Do their part as one united people

The report concluded that the collective strength of Singapore's society depends on its unity and how people care for each other. Underpinning this is a need to nurture a stronger culture of giving, especially those who have done well, and better connect donors and volunteers to local community needs. It also requires strengthening multi-racialism and the Singaporean identity, as well as creating more avenues for civic participation.
95

"It is clear that Singapore is strongest when we stand together – when we recognise that caring for each other is also the best way to care for ourselves, and when we develop a deep sense of kinship and trust in one another," the report said. "In particular, those who have succeeded should do their part to uplift others in society."

100 Ultimately, a "functioning and robust social compact creates trust", the report added. "It leads to a sense of assurance that someone's got our interests in mind – that we have got each other's backs." While some of the key shifts are underway, details of other initiatives will be announced in the coming months and at Budget 2024.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Yeoh writes that the Forward SG exercise was carried out with the intention to 'review and refresh Singapore's "social compact" ' (line 6). What are the key aspects of this social compact?
2. The Forward SG involved many Singaporeans in dialogue that concerned 'issues ranging from careers to ageing and environmental sustainability' (lines 9-10). What are the advantages and disadvantages of such a government-led approach?
3. Explain the contrast between what a 'good life' (line 12) previously meant and what it entails to younger Singaporeans today.
4. In your own words, explain what constitutes an 'education arms race' (line 25). What might be the possible benefits and costs of such an approach towards education? In what way(s) might such an approach to education be incompatible with a 'mentality that strives to learn and improve throughout life' (lines 25-26)?
5. It is suggested that 'Individual responsibility should go hand in hand with "a greater sense of collective responsibility" ' (line 28). In your opinion, how feasible is it to strike such a balance? Do you think that the suggestions on how to attain this, outlined from lines 28-30, would be effective and/or sufficient?
6. It is suggested that the government should seek to help Singaporeans in ' "hands" and "heart" jobs' (line 44) through enhancing financial support such as 'defraying the costs of obtaining a diploma and possibly topping up [the] Central Provident Fund (CPF)' (line 47) of 'Institute of Technical Education graduates' (line 46). Apart from financial obstacles, might there be other difficulties that people in "hands" and "heart" jobs face in Singapore? If so, how do you propose that such workers be better supported?
7. Suggest why it may be effective to address 'early gaps' (line 63) for 'children from lower-income families' (line 63) through ensuring that such children attend preschool regularly.
8. Why do the authors of the Forward SG report believe that 'considerations of fairness apply not just to today but also across generations' (lines 87-88)? In what ways may the decisions we make today concerning 'how we will prioritise our spending' (line 86) be unfair to or 'short-chang[e]' (line 89) future generations?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which all people in your society have the opportunity to achieve their full potential. (Cambridge 2023)
2. 'Power these days lies more with the people than the politicians.' To what extent is this true? (Cambridge 2021)
3. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
4. To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest? (Cambridge 2020)
5. To what extent can any society claim to be great? (Cambridge 2020)
6. Evaluate the effectiveness of government efforts to enhance people's quality of life in your society. (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
7. How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
8. Is a thriving economy the best measure of a good government? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
9. 'Governments are failing the people they are supposed to serve.' Discuss. (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
10. 'The key to good governance is in staying accountable to the people.' How far do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 CT)
11. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 CT)

SECTION B: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN FREEDOM AND STABILITY

Reading 8: 'Hard choices' for Singapore media after controversial law passed

EU 2 & 3

Annabelle Liang | Al Jazeera | 13 October 2021

This article will introduce you to:

- The Government's enacting of the Foreign Interference Countermeasures Act (FICA) to protect Singapore from foreign interference
- Various concerns about the effect of such a law in the country, particularly when the media and controversial views are already under strict regulation

Singapore's government says its new foreign interference law is needed to prevent outside meddling in the city state's domestic affairs. But independent news outlets and observers worry that the broadly-worded Foreign Interference Countermeasures Act (FICA) will further limit freedoms in the tightly-controlled country of 5.5 million people. An opposition member of parliament alluded to FICA as a "Trojan horse"³ before it was passed into law by an overwhelming majority a week ago.

Representatives from the ruling People's Action Party, which holds 83 of 93 parliamentary seats, all supported the bill, which the government says is necessary to counter alleged incidents of foreign interference. Home Affairs Minister K Shanmugam said the broad wording of FICA was intentional while stopping short of naming the countries it targets. "The difficulty that we face ... in dealing with this foreign interference issue is that out of 10,000 interactions, one might be the sort that we are interested in," he said. "And foreign agencies and even non-agencies, NGOs and others, will try and present a legitimate front. So the language has got to be broad enough to cover that – that what is apparently normal, but is actually not normal," he said in Parliament. Some people and entities will automatically be classified as "politically significant persons" under FICA, including political parties and members of parliament. Others can be given this status by the authorities (the Home Affairs ministry says the issue will be handled by an unnamed "competent authority") and they can challenge it by appealing to the home affairs minister, rather than the courts.

There is no mention of whether the "competent authority" needs to explain the decision – only that it must inform the person or entity that they are considered a "politically significant person". The names of the designated will also appear on a public list, according to the ministry. They will need to report "arrangements" with "foreign principals" and donations of 10,000 Singapore dollars (\$7,378) or more, among other rules. Any individual who allegedly publishes information on behalf of a "foreign principal" and towards a political end can also be fined up to 100,000 Singapore dollars (\$73,757) and jailed for 14 years if the affiliation is not declared. For entities, there is a maximum fine of 1 million Singapore dollars (\$737,550).

"There is no clarity on the extent of powers the home minister has under FICA, the intention behind the proposed laws, and how it applies to independent news organisations like us," said Kumaran Pillai, publisher of The Independent Singapore, a website. "Whether intentional or not, the government is setting up barriers to entry in the media landscape in Singapore," he added.

The Independent Singapore, which has 1.6 million unique visitors every month, routinely reports its finances in line with existing licensing requirements that prevent foreign funding. It has 10 staff and relies on advertisements to keep servers humming. "We do have foreign correspondents working on entertainment, lifestyle, regional and international pieces. If they are filing any local reports, we use

³ Defined as a person or thing that is used to trick an enemy in order to achieve a secret purpose (Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary)

35 them strictly for fact-based reporting,” Pillai told Al Jazeera. “I have instructed my editors to ensure that there is proper fact-checking and compliance. It is not the job of foreign contributors to add salt and pepper to our articles.”

‘A nuclear bomb’

40 Independent media outlets in Singapore have long come under fire from the authorities over alleged foreign links. The Online Citizen, a now-defunct sociopolitical website, was accused of employing foreigners to write largely negative articles about Singapore. It was recently shut after authorities said it failed to declare all its funding sources for 2020 when ordered.

45 New Naratif, meanwhile, an online current affairs website covering Southeast Asia established by three Singaporeans, was prevented from setting up operations in the city-state. The Accounting and Corporate Regulatory Authority (ACRA) said the website, which is funded via a membership model and collects subscription fees, “would appear to be funded by a number of foreigners”. The website had received grant funding from the Open Society Foundations, founded by billionaire financier George Soros.

50 Last week, during a response in Parliament, Shanmugam said the foundation had a “history of getting involved in the domestic politics of sovereign countries” and singled out New Naratif. Kirsten Han, who co-founded the site in 2017 and left the organisation last year, said it willingly provided information about the grant and that it “did not come with any expectation or ability to control the editorial decisions that we made”. New Naratif’s managing director, Thum Ping Tjin, a historian, said the website, which has its headquarters in Malaysia, has 1,221 active members from about 40 countries.

55 “Singapore is still our biggest country of subscribers, but it is a decreasing majority,” said Thum, who once represented Singapore as a swimmer and is an academic visitor at the University of Oxford’s Hertford College. He expects to lose more Singapore subscribers if the site is designated a “proscribed online location” under FICA. “It is a nuclear bomb. The way FICA works is by criminalising virtually everything and then giving the authorities discretion as to whether they prosecute you or not,” Thum said.

60 “They are trying to close off the Internet, basically, and ensure that there are no alternative and critical voices in Singapore. Because at this point, who else is there? There are a few other struggling outlets, but they don’t tackle politics the way New Naratif and The Online Citizen do, and quite rightly so, since they want to survive,” he added.

Strict laws

65 Singapore’s mass media landscape has been a near-duopoly for decades – between Singapore Press Holdings (SPH), which publishes daily national broadsheet The Straits Times, and Mediacorp, which runs the island’s television and radio stations. While both outlets say they are editorially independent, critics are more sceptical. SPH recently named a former minister as chair of its media business, in a government-led move which was condemned by opposition politicians.

70 Mediacorp, which grew out of public broadcaster Singapore Broadcasting Corporation, is owned by Temasek Holdings, the state investment fund. Its board includes the permanent secretary of the Home Affairs Ministry and the country’s non-resident ambassador to Kuwait.

A strict regulatory and licensing environment, coupled with sweeping censorship and defamation laws, have long weighed on freedom of expression in the island nation. In 2019, the Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (POFMA), which was introduced to tackle “fake news”, took

75 effect allowing Singapore ministers to order that anything deemed an “online falsehood” be taken down or have a “correction” published alongside it. The orders can be appealed to the courts, but POFMA has already been used against journalists, and activist Jolovan Wham was ordered to post a correction notice on a tweet he shared about Shanmugam’s parliamentary speech on FICA.

80 Singapore was placed at 160 out of 180 countries in the Reporters Without Borders World Press Freedom Index in 2021, which was compiled before FICA was passed. “Despite the ‘Switzerland of the East’ label often used in government propaganda, the city-state does not fall far short of China when it comes to suppressing media freedom,” the group said.

85 On Wednesday, in an open letter, Article19 and 10 other rights organisations, including a group of regional lawmakers, called on Singapore to withdraw the legislation, saying it breached international legal and human rights principles. “Almost any form of expression and association relating to politics, social justice or other matters of public interest in Singapore maybe ensnarled within the ambit of the legislation – making it difficult in turn, for the average individual to reasonably predict with precision what conduct may fall foul of the law,” the organisations wrote.

No known cases

90 Analysts say the media environment that emerges as a result of FICA could have a damaging effect even on SPH and Mediacorp. “It seems like in the government’s view, the ideal media is that you have SPH and Mediacorp, and they are both heavily read and trusted by Singaporeans,” said Ang Peng Hwa, a professor at the Nanyang Technological University’s Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information. “But that’s not how the news media ecosystem works anywhere in the world. You need a diversity of media, you need your oppositional and independent media sources,” he added. “And so 95 FICA looks to have the possibility of suppressing independent journalism as well as oppositional journalism. It is hard to see now, but in the long run, [the lack of competition] will hurt both SPH and Mediacorp.”

100 The ministry has stoutly defended the need for FICA and in a letter to the Straits Times just before it was passed stressed it would “not apply to Singaporeans discussing issues or advocating any matter”. There have been no known cases of Singapore journalists being involved in full-blown influence campaigns.

105 In the academic sphere, the country expelled Chinese-born American academic Huang Jing in 2017 for being an “agent of influence of a foreign country”. “He knowingly interacted with intelligence organisations and agents of the foreign country, and cooperated with them to influence the Singapore government’s foreign policy and public opinion in Singapore,” the Home Affairs Ministry said.

Although FICA does not specifically target journalists, it can be used if their ventures are found to be part of hostile information campaigns, said Eugene Tan, an associate law professor at Singapore Management University. “It’s not a question of whether but when FICA will be applied in such circumstances,” Tan said.

110 Tan, a veteran political commentator, does not believe the law will curtail independent journalism in the country. “I appreciate that it is a legitimate concern but only if FICA is misused by the authorities. It is crucial to recognise that there must be grounds for the law to be applied in the first place. So long as journalism is independent, that is it accurately represents the journalist’s reporting and viewpoints, and not done at the behest of a foreign proxy, FICA cannot be used.”

115 For Pillai, the reaches of the law are personal, as an independent publisher and executive committee member of the opposition Progress Singapore Party, which does not hold any parliamentary seats.

Pillai says he is currently allowed to “participate in party politics and get involved in any business without encumbrances”. “I am not sure how the new laws will impact my current working relationship in the various organisations that I am involved in today,” he told Al Jazeera. “Personally, I might have to make some hard choices in the future.”

120

For discussion/reflection:

1. What is being implied about FICA with the label of a ‘Trojan Horse’ (line 5)?
2. How convincing do you find Minister Shanmugan’s justification for the ‘broad wording of FICA’ (line 8)? Why or why not?
3. Based on lines 37 – 63, do you think that requiring independent news sites to either be funded locally, or alternatively banning news sites that receive significant foreign funding is an appropriate way to prevent foreign interference?
4. What was the author’s intention in providing details concerning ownership of Mediacorp and the identities of some board members (lines 69-71)?
5. Professor Ang’s believes that ‘[the lack of competition] will hurt both SPH and Mediacorp’ (lines 96-97). Can you explain in what way(s)?
6. Eugene Tan argues that the new law should worry us ‘only if FICA is misused by the authorities’ (line 111). How do far do you agree with such a perspective?
7. Do you think that the government’s approach towards the management of issues with social and/or political consequences tends to be about exercising greater control? Is such an approach always desirable? If not, what exceptions can you think of? Justify your answer.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘In a free society, there should be no restrictions on freedom of speech.’ Discuss. (Cambridge 2020)
2. Is regulation of the press desirable? (Cambridge 2017)
3. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 Common Test)
4. Do those who challenge the status quo have a place in your society? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
5. Assess the view that government regulation is the best way to achieve a trustworthy media. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)

Related case study:



Outrage in Malaysia as Zakir Naik suggests Chinese expulsion (Malaysia, 2019, Al Jazeera):

Malaysian leaders condemned Indian preacher Zakir Naik’s remarks, calling them inflammatory and harmful to national unity. Multiple ministers urged then-Prime Minister Mahathir to consider deportation, police questioned him, highlighting strong pushback against foreign-linked interference in Malaysia’s domestic racial politics. This incident can possibly lend legitimacy to the defence of a policy like FICA.



Australia’s new foreign-influence laws: Who is targeted? (Australia, 2018, the Interpreter)

Australia’s Foreign Influence Transparency Scheme requires individuals and entities conducting political lobbying for foreign principals to register their activities, aiming to expose covert influence from nations like China. FITS mandates that individuals or entities acting for foreign principals must register their activities on a public database to ensure transparency. Key levers include mandated transparency notices for disclosure, severe criminal penalties of up to five years’ imprisonment for non-compliance

SECTION B: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN FREEDOM AND STABILITY

Reading 9: Trusting surveillance in Singapore's 'Smart Nation'

EU 2-3

Teo Yi-Ling and Muhammad Faizal Abdul Rahman | *The Diplomat* | 26 January 2021

This article will help you to understand how/why:

- Mass surveillance can be harnessed to deliver positive social and medical outcomes, but also poses serious risks if it is misused or abused
- The maturing of the electorate leads to greater awareness and interrogation of policies concerning mass surveillance
- The TraceTogether dispute highlights the need for Singaporeans to renegotiate the social contract question of data privacy

As of December 31, 2020, Singapore's TraceTogether COVID-19 contact tracing program had attained a national adoption rate of over 70 percent. In order to nudge the public toward adoption, the government had invested significantly in technology and community outreach, responding to initial public concerns over the app's functionality, data security, and privacy protection. These issues had weighed heavily on the public's side of the allegorical seesaw of trust, but by end of 2020, the government appeared to have successfully calibrated its priorities for tackling public health concerns with assurance about respect for personal privacy.

This achievement would have been a fitting coda to the program's launch, but for the Singapore government's disclosure on January 4 that in addition to COVID-19 contact tracing, TraceTogether data could be used for the purpose of criminal investigations. Seen as an apparent revocation of promises to the contrary, the announcement came as a bombshell for many. Decried as a betrayal of public trust and policy backpedalling, notwithstanding the technical legality of using TraceTogether data under the Criminal Procedure Code (CPC), the revelation created fodder for political contestation. Further exacerbating the damage was the fact that the government is not subject to the Personal Data Protection Act (PDPA). In an attempt to assuage public outrage, a new law limiting access to TraceTogether data for criminal investigations is now being expedited through parliament.

What could this decline in trust mean for Singapore's Smart Nation efforts, in which surveillance plays a prominent role? A key factor of Singapore's phenomenal transformation "from third world to first" is arguably the extensive role of the government in numerous aspects of social and economic development. In the interests of peace and prosperity, people trust and toe the line of governance models that strike a balance between pragmatism and idealism. The Smart Nation scheme, which leverages data, is the form this model takes in the digital age. This model was never without criticism, but there are growing sentiments pejoratively framing it as "big government."

Three reasons could explain the rise of these sentiments. First, the country's transformation has met most people's basic physiological and security needs, and now there is a rising demand for self-actualization needs, such as privacy and ideological expression. Second, the vast information space online is flooded with facts, fiction, and fallacies that make clear-headed judgement difficult. This situation could create speed bumps in trust-building between the government and public and blur the lines between what is necessary and what is ideal.

Third, there is an ascendant international commentary that frames "big government" in absolute terms of state over-reach and tyranny, inviting comparisons to what the West regards as techno-authoritarian powers, such as China. This trend could challenge national crisis management, as the efforts of national institutions, especially regarding data surveillance, may be perceived as malign attempts to consolidate political power instead of providing public goods like health and safety.

Popular culture and political discourse often cast data surveillance in an ominous light. In this scenario, data surveillance is the tool of profiteering technological companies or malign political powers aiming to control the people. This makes the discourse of individual privacy vs public good a difficult and emotive one.

- 40 In reality, another scenario already exists. Surveillance is conceptually broad and is a powerful tool for the common good. Data collection and analysis informs the design and distribution of public goods such as healthcare, security, transportation, and workplace safety that are vital to the functioning of society. For example, data on crowd movements aids transport planning and police patrols to deter crime. Data on sanitation could aid water management and detection of infectious diseases.
- 45 Emphasizing these realities could support trust-building as the government demonstrates *care* for the people and *competency* in efficiently providing public goods and meeting Smart Nation goals. But trust also entails *credibility* in which the government's promises on the use of data matters, as well as the effective *communication* of these promises.

- 50 Trust is a fundamental element of any relationship: it is hard-won, requires continual management, and is all too easily broken. In the wake of this TraceTogether controversy, should government priorities focus on repairing trust rather than efficiency? This will entail the political will to address the longstanding elephant in the room: privacy.

- 55 In a world of social media and smartphone applications, people are grappling with the boundaries of privacy and how compromises in sharing personal identifiable data could benefit or harm them. With the PDPA, most conversations on privacy protection in Singapore were business-facing. The TraceTogether controversy has broadened public discussions on privacy as a personal right that may supersede national priorities, and what a government can but should not do. The conversations are increasingly spotlighting the government as data surveillance becomes more apparent, and formal regulation binding the government to its promises of data privacy protection may go some way to
- 60 assure the public.

- 65 In December 2020, the Law Reform Commission of the Singapore Academy of Law issued a report on the sufficiency and effectiveness of existing legal protections with regard to unlawful disclosure and serious misuse of private information. The report concluded that the current patchwork of legal protections has gaps, shortcomings, and difficult to navigate. The report proposes a new law to remediate the situation, defining "private information" as that about which an individual has a "reasonable expectation of privacy." Most significantly, it proposes that this new law should bind the Singapore government in this respect.

- 70 The last five years have seen a flurry of legislative moves to speed up the drive to the Smart Nation program. Privacy rights were arguably much lower in priority but now feature more significantly in public expectations, hence the need to renegotiate the social contract. In this renegotiation, data privacy rights and the proposed law are considerations that the government must reckon with. On the public's part, it may have to bear with slower technological progress, as it will be unrealistic to expect the government to provide seamless public goods without obtaining the data necessary to understand people's needs. However, if the social contract remains uncertain, trust-building on the road to Smart
- 75 Nation will continue to face speed bumps.

For discussion/reflection:

1. The authors referenced public perceptions of 'policy backpedalling' (line 12) on the part of the government's use of TraceTogether data. Based on additional research, if necessary, explain why such a perception came about.
2. In your own words, explain what is meant by the claim that 'governance models [strike] a balance between pragmatism and idealism' (lines 21-22).

3. Summarise the key developments that have led to the ascendancy of scepticism and questioning attitudes concerning 'big government' (line 23)
4. According to the authors, what makes public discussion concerning privacy and data surveillance a particularly fraught with 'difficult[y]' (line 38)? Based on the level of the trust you believe exists between the government and Singaporeans, is such a 'discussion' easier or harder compared to other countries/societies?
5. Based on lines 46-49, explain in your own words how the authors believe the government could build trust where data surveillance and Smart Nation goals are concerned.
6. In what way has the TraceTogether controversy (line 57) been beneficial?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Is modern technology a benefit or threat to democracy? (Cambridge 2020)
2. How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
3. 'We are less free than before.' How far do you agree with this view of modern society? (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
4. 'There is no point in resisting surveillance.' Do you agree? (RI 2020 Y5 Promo)
5. 'Surveillance of the people is a necessary evil.' Discuss. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelim)
6. Should a government always listen to its people? (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
7. Discuss the Claim that the digital age has made it more challenging for political leaders to govern today. (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
8. How far should the State be allowed to restrict individual rights when security is at stake? (RI 2017 Y5 CT1)
9. 'Personal privacy and national security cannot co-exist.' Comment. (RI 2015 Y5 CT1)
10. 'For the sake of security, a nation has every right to monitor its citizens.' Discuss. (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)

Related case studies:

 [**False panacea: Abusive surveillance in the name of public health**](#) (Various countries, 2020, Freedom House): *This article examines the rise of different surveillance technologies in use by governments in cooperation with technology companies to monitor populations in name of public health concerns which at the same time enables governments to collect data for other more nefarious purposes. In particular, it provides an extensive analysis of how China uses AI to develop apps that surveil population movement.*

 [**South Korea's success in controlling disease is due to its acceptance of surveillance**](#) (South Korea, 2020, The Conversation): *This article reviews the success of South Korea in using surveillance using cell phone and credit card information, along with the employment of large numbers of CCTV, without significant compromise of personal data in locating and containing outbreaks of Covid-19.*

SECTION B: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN FREEDOM AND STABILITY

Reading 10: The myth of 'trade-offs'

EU 2, 3 & 5

Calvin Cheng | Straits Times | 28 March 2015

This next reading will introduce you to:

- The challenges governments face in maintaining equilibrium between individual rights and state priorities.
- Singapore's unique model of governance, its merits and shortcomings, as well as how a country's economic dependencies can shape its political thinking.

The Western press has been relentless in trotting out the opinion that Mr Lee Kuan Yew had built Singapore's undeniable economic success while trading off fundamental civil liberties. Much as I understand that it is in the West's fundamental DNA to assert certain inalienable freedoms, as a Singaporean, I strenuously object that there has been any such trade-off.

- 5 Some of my Western friends who have never lived here for any period of time have sometimes self-righteously proclaimed, no doubt after reading the clichés in the media, that they could never live under the "stifling and draconian" laws that we have.

- 10 My answer to them is simple: Are you the sort to urinate in public when a toilet isn't available, the sort to vandalise public property, the sort that would leave a mess in a public toilet that you share with others? Are you the sort who would throw rubbish on the streets for others to pick up, the sort that would stick gum on train doors or leave them on the floor to dry up into one ugly black scar in the pavement? Are you perhaps a drug smuggler? Because we execute those. Or maybe you molest women? Because we would whip you. Are you the sort that would get drunk and then get into fights and maybe beat up a stranger in the bar? Back home you may get away with it but if you are that sort, 15 then maybe this place isn't for you.

In short, are you a civilised person who wants to live in a civilised society? Because the things you cannot do in Singapore are precisely the sort that civilised people should not do anyway. If you are, you have nothing to fear.

- 20 Or maybe like the Western press has kept saying these few days in their commentaries on Mr Lee, you fear that you could be locked up because we do not have freedom of speech?

Do you want to come here and insult other people's race and religion? Maybe these are fundamental freedoms in your country, but in ours, because we have experienced deadly racial riots at the birth of our country, these are a no-no. But then again, why would you want to purposely offend others anyway?

- 25 Or maybe you want to tell lies about our public figures, accuse them of corruption when you have no evidence to back them up, or accuse them of stealing, cheating, or all manner of untruths? If so, then be prepared to be sued for libel. Even if Western societies think that you can say these things about your political figures, we don't and we are better for it.

- 30 And those political opponents of Mr Lee who have been bankrupted, allegedly because they were such formidable foes? No such thing. Mr JB Jeyaretnam and Mr Chee Soon Juan may be the martyrs much adored by the Western press, but have you heard of Mr Chiam See Tong, the longest-serving opposition Member of Parliament who won five consecutive elections against Mr Lee's People's Action Party? Or Mr Low Thia Kiang, who not only won five consecutive general elections, but in the last one

35 in 2011, also led a team that unseated the incumbent Minister for Foreign Affairs and our first-ever female Cabinet minister?

Both these opposition MPs have never been sued, much less bankrupted. In fact, Mr Chiam won several libel lawsuits against Mr Lee's ministers. You would never have heard of them, or have chosen not to, because it doesn't fit the Western narrative that legitimate opposition was stifled by Mr Lee through lawsuits. It doesn't suit your narrative of trade-offs. The fact is that every single opposition
40 politician successfully sued for libel engaged in the type of politics that we do not want, the kind founded on vicious lies being told in the name of political campaigning.

What about detention without trial? Again and again ad nauseam, the Western press has used the example of Operation Cold Store to bolster its narrative of Mr Lee as an autocrat, where 111 left-wing politicians were arrested on suspicion of being communist in 1964.

45 But what about Operation Demetrius, where in 1971, 342 persons suspected of being involved with the IRA were detained without trial by the British Army? Or closer to the present where thousands have been interred without trial by the United States in Guantanamo Bay on suspicion of being terrorists? Firstly, detention without trial is not something used only by the Singapore Government, but countries need to make their own judgment about applying such laws when they feel their security
50 is threatened and the normal judicial process is inadequate; in the 60s and 70s, communists inciting armed revolution were Singapore's greatest threat.

Whether those people were indeed communists will be a question no doubt debated endlessly by historians, in the same way as whether the 342 in Northern Ireland were indeed IRA members, or the thousands in Guantanamo Bay were indeed terrorists.

55 So where is the trade-off? How are we unfree? I tell you what freedom is.

Freedom is being able to walk on the streets unmolested in the wee hours in the morning, to be able to leave one's door open and not fear that one would be burgled. Freedom is the woman who can ride buses and trains alone; freedom is not having to avoid certain subway stations after night falls. Freedom is knowing our children can go to school without fear of drugs, or being mowed down by
60 some insane person with a gun. Freedom is knowing that we are not bound by our class, our race, our religion, and we can excel for the individuals that we are - the freedom to accomplish. Freedom is living in one of the least corrupt societies in the world, knowing that our ability to get things done is not going to be limited by our ability to pay someone. Freedom is fresh air and clean streets, because nothing is more inimical to our liberty of movement than being trapped at home because of
65 suffocating smog.

These are the freedoms that Singaporeans have, freedoms that were built on the vision and hard work of Mr Lee, our first Prime Minister. And we have all of these, these liberties, while also being one of the richest countries in the world.

There was no trade-off. Not for us.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Explain in your own words, the 'trade-off' that Cheng believes the 'Western press' (line 1) asserts Singapore has made.
2. In this piece, Cheng asserts that fundamental civil liberties, valued in more liberal democracies, such as freedom of speech and expression, ultimately restrict the social freedoms Singaporeans today enjoy. How valid is this perspective?

3. Cheng provides a rebuttal (lines 45-54) of claims that Operation Cold Store (lines 43-44) offers proof that Singapore's Founding Father Mr Lee Kuan Yew was 'an autocrat' (line 43). How convinced are you by his rebuttal? Why or why not?
4. From Singapore's post-independence years to now, has the country relaxed its curbs on freedoms, and if so, how?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'Freedom of speech is key to building a strong democracy.' To what extent is this true? (RI 2020 Term 3 Y6 Common Essay Assignment)
2. How far, in your society, should unpopular views be open to discussion? (Cambridge 2013)
3. Should there be limits to freedom of speech in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
4. Is it ever justified to sacrifice human rights for a country's progress? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
5. It has been said that Singapore is economically First World but socially Third World. What is your view? (RI 2011 Y6 Prelim)
6. 'Governments have a right to censor undesirable elements of their nations' history.' Do you agree? (RI 2011 Y6 Prelim)
7. 'We are less free than before.' How far do you agree with this view of modern society? (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)

SECTION B: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN FREEDOM AND STABILITY

Reading 11: Concessions Singaporeans make in exchange for effective crisis management **EU 2 -4**

Adapted from What Singapore Can Tell the World About Personal Liberty | Jerrine Tan | WIRED | 29 April 2020

This next reading will introduce you to:

- The idea that efficient governance is as much about a compliant and malleable people as it is about an efficient and competent government
- The view that Singapore appears to have chosen a trade-off between curtailed freedoms and ignored inequalities, and a government that is given the leeway to act decisively and efficiently
- The possible downsides whereby too much responsibility is ceded to the authorities

5 In mid-January I returned to the US from a visit home to Singapore, where people were already worried about the novel coronavirus spreading in China. All through February, it was bizarre to observe business as usual in the US. Western media reports mostly critiqued the authoritarian lockdown measures implemented by China—the same measures that have since been adopted in various forms across the world as it became clear that containment was key to managing the crisis. Complacency and an unwillingness to call for severe restrictions to mobility early on in the name of not violating individual liberty doomed the US to its ongoing crisis. Donald Trump’s refusal to take the virus seriously and the delays in lockdown were myopic, prideful, and wilfully ignorant. Western liberal democracies will not emerge from this crisis with much—or any—moral or political clout.

10 Instead, the world will look to places that have handled this crisis well, or at least better.

In the early stages of the outbreak, Singapore was roundly lauded for its prompt and efficient response, ensuring a quick flattening of the curve. But if we are to learn lessons from Singapore, they should be clear-eyed, understanding how and why it was able to respond in the ways it did, not only in a time of crisis but also because of how it operated before.

15 The Singapore government, synonymous with the PAP (People's Action Party), managed the first wave of infections well. Its system of contact-tracing is world-class. Masks were rationed and distributed. As the second wave of imported infections started rolling in, hotels served as dedicated quarantine rooms for returning Singaporeans, which ensured safe and proper physical distancing while propping up the ailing hotel industry and saving jobs.

20 But managing a crisis well does not mean that the problematic aspects of a government go away. In fact, effective crisis management can be aided by these characteristics. In *The Economist*, Kishore Mahbubani chalks the success of China, South Korea, and Singapore up to “quality of governance and cultural confidence of their societies.” But this claim is reductive. The PAP is notorious for draconian censorship laws, harsh retaliation against dissenters, and the suppression of other political parties.

25 In the past month, the appeal to repeal Section 377A, a relic of colonial law criminalizing sex between two men, was dismissed. A local activist was jailed for unfavourably comparing Singapore’s judiciary system to Malaysia’s. These events largely passed unremarked due to the onslaught of Covid-19 news.

Is freedom and a robust democracy the price to pay for effective crisis management?

30 In late March, as flights from the US to Singapore got cancelled for the indefinite future, I found myself grappling for the first time in my life with the existential and psychic pain of not being able to return home if I wanted to. Remaining in a country that quickly surged to have the most cases in the world, I began to wonder about the price I was willing to pay to ensure that the Singapore government acted in a way that would secure the safety of my family. I found myself sinking into

35 helpless worry and making wishful deals in the dark with my government: *Get Singapore through this. If my parents stay healthy until I can get home, I swear I'll never speak ill of the government again.* In a state of emergency, more than a few of us will find ourselves cutting deals with god, the devil, or the government alike.

40 For now, Singapore has extended its “circuit breaker” period till June 1. The euphemistic term denotes stringent lockdown rules: closure of schools and non-essential businesses, mandatory mask-wearing (or risk heavy fines), among other measures. Crises invite tone-deaf and ill-informed opinions of many, including out of touch philosophers. Italian philosopher Giorgio Agamben criticized current social-distancing measures as antihumanist—as a trade-off of quality of life for the mere sustenance of biological life, what he terms “bare life.” Agamben’s essay is misguided at best. In
45 order to have quality of life, you need first to *be alive*.

But Agamben’s notion of bare life is helpful in thinking about a different context—the conditions we are willing to live under in everyday life in order to ensure efficient response in a state of emergency. Emergency measures do not *simply* work. They work when a populace has been conditioned for years to accept instruction. Singapore is known for its harsh punishments—ask Michael Fay, the American
50 who was notoriously caned for vandalism, despite Bill Clinton’s plea for clemency—and has made examples of a handful of political dissidents, names that pass lips in hushed whispers. But for the Baby Boomer generation who saw vast improvements in quality of life, wealth, and social mobility, freedom to paint graffiti and criticize a government that has in fact served them well is not much to give up.

55 Agamben worries that the draconian emergency measures put in place today could lead to future oppression. Fair enough. But what is more important to consider is the implication—and the efficiency— of the reverse: that states with fuller control can more effectively institute stringent measures. Singapore is able to respond quickly and efficiently in times like this because its government has always wielded absolute control over the state, with an iron fist and a whip in it. In
60 times of crisis, when this form of authoritative instruction saves lives, we might call it good. But in order for it to work in times of crisis, one must be willing to always live under this yoke. This, it seems, is the price many Singaporeans are willing to pay.

The US now faces the problem of people protesting stay-at-home recommendations. Singapore has no such problem. Unlicensed protest is illegal.

65 Singapore’s former Prime Minister Lee Kwan Yew once said, “If Singapore is a nanny-state, then I am proud to have fostered one.” The problem with a nanny state, like a helicopter parent, is that it breeds reliance. And coddled children are not only unable to think for themselves, they’re also unwilling to think about others. Suddenly unable to rely fully on the government to tell us what to do for ourselves, Singaporeans will have to find out if we are able to behave in a way that protects
70 others.

Across the world, the virus is laying bare the cruelties inherent in existing systems. In America, black and marginalized communities are getting infected and dying disproportionately. With the second wave of infections, the same is proving to be true in Singapore. Unchecked clusters of infection have mushroomed among the migrant worker communities, largely due to a lack of testing and abysmal,
75 overcrowded living conditions. On April 5, two workers’ dormitories were gazetted as isolation areas, keeping over 20,000 in shamefully cramped areas. As of April 20, more than 19 workers’ dormitories had been sealed off. Singaporeans outraged by the spread of infections among foreign workers and by their living conditions were chided by the minister for manpower, who shot back that citizens should not “demoralize [her team] with finger-pointing.” The problem with political

80 paternalism that conflates governing with parenting is that it allows governments to place themselves beyond reproach.

The crisis is revealing an open secret of the country—that gleaming Singapore is built on the backs of low-wage foreign labour. Even appeals to Singaporeans to be empathetic towards labourers are implicitly anchored in capitalism: The minister for home affairs said, by way of imploring
85 Singaporeans to be more tolerant, “They clean Singapore, they build our HDB flats ... they handle our waste management... they are helping us build our prosperity.” To say they are human should have sufficed.

Meanwhile, Singaporean media engages in a poisonous and dehumanizing rhetoric, distinguishing between new cases of “migrant worker” and “local” infections. For an English teacher, this is a
90 senseless distinction. What do we think “local” means? As a humanities scholar, when I say dehumanizing rhetoric, I don’t just mean that it dehumanizes the workers, it dehumanizes *me*. To imagine that I am more worthy than a migrant worker makes *me* bereft. The way this debacle has been discussed shores up the unequal ways we view different sets of humans.

Covid-19 is literalizing the idea that the measure of a civilization is how it treats its weakest members.
95 The well-being of everyone is contingent upon protecting the most vulnerable among us. The world is only as close to healing as the country struggling the most with the virus right now. Failures of health care systems and systemic racism and inequality are inhumane in and of themselves. If we forget that, they will also come back to bite us in a crisis.

100 In Singapore, it is clear that our ability to deal with an emergency has to do with the existing status quo and the concessions we are willing to make in everyday life, both in terms of personal liberty and the inequalities that we accept or ignore for others. Life on the tropical island paradise is mostly good. But remember that to remain in Eden, Adam and Eve had to promise never to eat of the tree of knowledge. Draconian quarantine policing aside, often it is the injunction of the smallest liberties that most define how free we are.

105 The world will survive Covid-19. When it does, we would all do well to consider just how much the freedom to taste of fruit is worth, and how easily we can sleep in our beds when others creak in cots or on floors with 12 to 19 others in their room. What concessions are we willing to make in a time of acute crisis in order to tide us over? What concessions are we willing to make in times of peace and prosperity in order to have the confidence that there will be effective management when crisis strikes
110 in the future? For better or worse, as the crisis draws on, Singapore may well hold the answer to those questions.

For discussion/reflection:

1. What does Tan mean by arguing that ‘effective crisis management can be aided by [problematic aspects of a government]’ (line 22)? What are these ‘problematic aspects’, and why do these aid in crisis management?
2. Tan suggests that ‘emergency measures’ (line 49) are unlikely to be effective unless a society ‘has been conditioned for years to accept instruction’ (lines 49-50). Attempt to articulate and explain Tan’s logic as clearly as possible. Do you find this idea convincing? What assumptions might she be making, and why might they not necessarily be true?
3. Is the kind of ‘condition[ing]’ (line 49) Tan suggests is happening easier or harder to carry out given the prevailing societal values and beliefs in Singapore?
4. According to Tan, what are some adverse consequences of governing a country as a ‘nanny-state’ (line 66)? Can you think of any others, apart from what she has identified?

5. In your own words, explain what Tan means when she asserts that 'political paternalism that conflates governing with parenting [allows] governments to place themselves beyond reproach' (lines 80-82).
6. Do you agree with the perspective that 'the measure of a civilization is how it treats its weakest members' (line 95)? Why or why not?
7. To what extent should a government sacrifice its citizens' freedom in a bid to achieve safety for its society? Are there any limits you can think of that should not be breached?
8. How can governments continue to maintain trust between its citizens in the midst of continuing crises?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent can any society claim to be great? (Cambridge 2020)
2. Do events, rather than politicians, shape the future? (Cambridge 2017)
3. Consider the view that efficient government is more important than democracy. (Cambridge 2011)
4. 'Governments are failing the people they are supposed to serve.' Discuss. (RI 2023 Y6 CT)
5. 'Elections do not make a free country.' What is your view? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
6. Is it ever justified to sacrifice human rights for a country's progress? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
7. To what extent have people given up their freedom for comfort? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
8. 'It is better to obey than to question.' How far is this true of your society? (RI 2014 Y6 CT2)
9. 'An educated people can be easily governed.' Is this a valid statement? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelim)

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 12: Of race and national identity

EU 2 & 4

Ng Jun Sen | Today Online | 23 November 2021

This reading will help you understand:

- That different groups in society have valid concerns linked to their identities
- Why such groups have a right to advocate for change
- What the government can and should do to listen and act as a fair and honest broker
- Possible approaches to help Singapore manage such tensions and move forward as a society
- How adopting a 'trader' instinct, which entails working towards reciprocity, trust and mutual benefit, may be beneficial

Different segments of Singapore's population, whose identities may be linked to their gender, ethnicity or sexual orientation, have concerns that are important and cannot be dismissed as illegitimate or exaggerated, Finance Minister Lawrence Wong said on Tuesday (Nov 23).

- 5 "That is what a fair and just society must mean. And we cannot — in the name of avoiding the dangers of identity politics — deny the rights of a variety of groups to organise themselves, so as to gain recognition for their concerns or seek to improve their conditions," Mr Wong added. On its part, the Government will not let any group feel unheard, excluded or ostracised, he said.

- 10 Delivering a keynote speech at a conference on identity organised by the Institute of Policy Studies (IPS) and the S Rajaratnam School of International Studies (RSIS), Mr Wong spoke about the growing trend of identity politics and tribalism dividing countries despite their governments' efforts to forge a common nationality. The minister last spoke on the topic of race in June at another IPS-RSIS conference, following a spate of racist incidents at the time. On Tuesday, he noted how other aspects of identity have surfaced since then, surrounding gender, sex or other causes for which people feel strongly.

- 15 "This is not surprising: The natural instinct of humans is to look out for those who are most like us. Around the world, we see the rise of what we might call a 'new tribalism' in politics, or 'identity politics' as it is commonly described," he said. In ethnically homogeneous countries such as Poland, for example, a "new tribalism" among people emerged out of differences in views on LGBTQ (lesbians, gays, bisexual, transgender or queer) rights, with supporters and opposers of LGBTQ rights in a standoff.

- 20 Melting-pot societies such as the United States, too, have seen the rise of tribalism and identity politics based on which political party they support, causing even public health measures such as mask-wearing or vaccination to become markers of such identities, Mr Wong noted. He suggested that the rise of tribalism was linked closely to the rise of individualism as the "reigning ethos", which came at the expense of community and weakened connections between people. This has caused them to fall back on such primeval defences that run deep in human societies when they feel lonely and alienated. "Tribalism is inherently exclusionary and it's based on mutual hate: 'Us' versus 'them', 'friend' versus 'foe'. Once this sort of tribal identity takes root, it becomes difficult to achieve any compromise," Mr Wong said. "Because when we anchor our politics on identity, any compromise seems like dishonour."

- 30 Singapore, too, cannot assume that its harmony is solid or permanent, as Singaporeans' identities are formed from a diverse racial mix of three major Asian civilisational complexes — China, India, and Southeast Asia — with none of the long history or indigenous cultures in these civilisations to hold Singapore together. Before the 1964 race riots, Singapore experienced "a far more violent conflict"

35 between Hokkiens and Teochews in 1854 that had led to more than 400 people being killed, more wounded, and about 300 houses burned in more than 10 days of riots, Mr Wong said. The sectarian clash, based on historical records, came about due to a rebellion in China. "It seems astounding to us today, but barely 150 years ago, tribal identities among Chinese here in Singapore trumped their racial, cultural or national identity as Chinese," he added.

40 "Can we then really be sure, with the rise of China, India and Southeast Asia, that Singaporean nationalism will not deconstruct again into Chinese, Indian and Malay nationalisms?" He noted that Singapore has managed to avoid serious conflicts because its founding leaders went to great lengths to put in place measures to safeguard racial and religious harmony. This meant tough action such as the Internal Security Act and short-term unpopular policies such as making English the main medium of instruction in schools, and the Housing and Development Board's Ethnic Integration Policy.

45 The policy helps to ensure a balanced mix of various ethnic communities in public housing estates and prevent the formation of racial enclaves. "This harmonious state of affairs will always be on a knife-edge; so it needs constant attention and careful management," Mr Wong emphasised.

Two recent webinars organised by TODAY and that were broadcast live on Instagram and TikTok also discussed issues of identity. One, on race and religion, focused on how social media and the Covid-19

50 pandemic have affected race relations and Singaporeans' perceptions of racial and religious issues. In the second, panellists discussed LGBTQ issues, such as the discrimination they face, media representation of the LGBTQ community and how individuals can make a difference by having constructive conversations about these matters.

Instead of ignoring identities and tribes, Singapore has to recognise that the pull of identity politics

55 arises from real differences in lived realities as a starting point. Mr Wong suggested five possible approaches to address the competing demands of diverse identity groups while maintaining a cohesive and harmonious society.

1. Strengthen human relationships

First, he advocated for Singaporeans to strengthen their spirit of reciprocity and kinship at the daily level, which would ultimately increase the mutual trust between people. "We must be good friends,

60 good neighbours, good Samaritans," he said. While the Government cannot compel people to build relationships, it can work to gird social norms — in caring for others, kindness and graciousness — that bring people together.

2. Avoid stereotyping groups of people

People should avoid assuming that each community is monolithic or homogenous. Referring to his previous speech on race, Mr Wong said that the phrase "Chinese privilege" is a form of stereotype —

65 a female Chinese from a poor background would have a vastly different lived experience compared to a male Chinese from a wealthy family, for example. "Minorities especially are subject to such prejudices; and all of us must be more conscious of the stereotypes we might harbour. We must avoid reducing our understanding of each other to a single dimension," he said. Mr Wong added: "We may be Chinese, Malay, Indian, Eurasian, or any other race. But we are first and foremost Singaporeans.

70 Likewise, regardless of our gender or sexual orientations, regardless of the cause we champion, we are all Singaporeans, first and foremost.

3. Singaporeans are traders by nature

While humans are tribalists, Singaporeans are also traders by nature, Mr Wong said, noting Singapore's entrepot history. Traders are characterised by the desire to explore the unknown, meet new people to trade and live with, and grounded on norms of reciprocity, trust and mutual benefit.

75 "This same instinct is crucial in setting the tone of our society," he added. "We must continue in this vein — continue to engage with one another, cooperate and work towards mutual benefit. We must

do so not only with those outside Singapore, but also between different segments of Singaporeans as well.” That means listening, understanding, compromising and negotiating for win-win outcomes, knowing that the community will be stronger by cooperation.

4. Giving hope through inclusive growth

80 Mr Wong said that the Government must continue to give Singaporeans reason to “hope and a fair chance to have a good life”, noting the rising inequalities elsewhere in the world that have led to economic woes and, consequently, extreme politics. “We must never allow this to happen in Singapore. So we will continue to work hard to promote inclusive growth and to ensure that all Singaporeans can succeed in their pursuits.” Through this, Singapore will be able to break out of having
85 a zero-sum mindset, in which the success of one group comes at the expense of another.

5. Government as a fair and honest broker

Undergirding this is the Government’s duty to be fair and honest, even with the difficulties in establishing consensus on controversial issues. “In such cases, the Government will do our utmost to recognise the challenges and needs of different groups, decide on the appropriate policy, and convince
90 the rest of society that this is a fair way to move forward,” Mr Wong said, referring to policies such as the Ethnic Integration Policy and the Special Assistance Plan for schools, which promotes the learning of Chinese language, culture and history.

Mr Wong also said that the authorities will never waver from its commitment to work with people to broaden common space and to build a society where every Singaporean can express their views and be empowered to effect positive change. “We may not always arrive at a perfect solution.... but we
95 will never let any group feel unheard, ignored or excluded. We will never let any group feel boxed in or ostracised. All must feel they are part of the Singapore conversation, all must feel they are part of the Singapore family, all must feel there is hope.”

Discussion questions are found at the end of Reading 13

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 13: Unpacking the government narrative about 'tribalism' in Singapore

EU 2 & 4

*Adapted from The Trouble with 'Tribal' – The Discomforts of Identity Politics in Singapore | Ng Yi-Sheng
/Rice Media | 6 January 2022*

This reading will help you understand:

- The reductive understanding that depicts 'tribalism' to be always wrong or bad for society
- Why the theoretical distinction between 'tribalism' and 'community' may not always hold in real life
- Why appealing to a common Singaporean identity as a way to avoid stereotyping different groups of people can actually be exclusionary, since many who reside in Singapore are non-citizens
- The limits of adopting a 'trader's instinct' in order to build harmonious relationships
- Why the definition of 'Chinese privilege' as an over-generalisation of the diverse experiences of Chinese Singaporeans is actually a mischaracterization
- Why values like democracy, justice, equality, and progress, should not simply be sacrificed for peace

On Tuesday, 23 November, the Minister for Finance, Lawrence Wong, and I spoke at the IPS-RSIS Conference on Identity. He was a guest of honour, delivering the opening speech with a follow-up dialogue and Q&A; I was a respondent on a panel. He had an hour on stage to disclose how the nation's leadership views identity politics; I had four minutes via Zoom.

- 5 Still, I've been asked to share a commentary on his speech, and I can see why some insight would be appreciated since The Straits Times and TODAY have given us two wildly different perspectives on the same talk. Was Wong issuing a warning (see ST: "New forms of tribalism can take root and affect politics in Singapore")? Or was he opening up for reform (see TODAY: "Concerns of groups such as women, minorities, LGBTQ are important, cannot be dismissed as 'illegitimate or exaggerated'")?
- 10 If you ask me, ST's headline is more accurate. Lawrence Wong spent most of his talk elaborating on the dangers of identity politics, which he claims to have sparked racial riots in years long past and may fuel culture wars in the future. At one point, he described tribalism as "an ancient narcotic," which makes it sound stupendously frightening.

- 15 There's also the usual celebration of Singapore's status quo ("different tribes have lived peacefully for more than half a century here") and issued the standard warning that the situation is critically unstable ("This harmonious state of affairs will always be on a knife-edge").

- 20 Now, it's true some progressive statements were made. He mentioned "LGBTQ persons feeling that society does not accept them" as a valid concern—this is original, indeed daring, content that we have not heard before from a government leader. Or that "we cannot—in the name of avoiding the dangers of identity politics—deny the rights of a variety of groups to organise themselves, to gain recognition for their concerns, or seek to improve their conditions and well-being."

- 25 There's even promise that "we will never let any group feel unheard, ignored or excluded." But I don't necessarily believe this speech signals a radical new turn in government policy, even though folks like political scientist Elvin Ong are predicting that it's heralding an upcoming repeal of Section 377A. If anything, it's a missed opportunity because I believe that Wong is more than able, and had the platform at this conference, to start a dialogue on how Singapore can shift policy to embrace those among us who feel sidelined by policy.

Still, my sense is that those of us who've historically felt "unheard, ignored, or excluded" are going to have to bear that burden a little longer.

A distracting history lesson on tribes

30 Suppose you've only read the Straits Times' edited reprint of Wong's speech. In that case, you'd have missed out on an eccentric intro: an ancient Roman history lesson, explaining the origins of the words "tribe" (from the voting unit, "Tribus") and "citizen" (from the invention of the Roman citizen, "civitas Romana"). It's a fun opportunity to show off a good grasp of general knowledge and Latin, and I won't begrudge him that.

35 But there's a problem with Lawrence Wong's fascination with history—simultaneously seduced by tradition and nostalgia while also determined to defend the progress of present-day Singapore. There are repeated contradictions in assessing tribalism in the past versus the present.

Tribalism is thousands of years old, he says. But tribalism is also a modern phenomenon, reborn through "new forms of identity politics". Tribalism was good when it inspired Chinese, Indian, and Indonesian nationalism in the 1940s, paving the way for Singaporean nationalism. But tribalism is bad now because it could lead to Singaporean disunity. Tribalism is frowned upon now because it arises out of the loneliness caused by individualism. But tribalism was worse in the distant past when it caused the bloody Hokkien-Teochew riots of 1854.

45 He does, at one point, attempt to lay down some definitions for us. "Tribalism may feel like community," he says. "But the two are not the same. Community is about inclusive connections, and it's based on mutual affection. Tribalism is inherently exclusionary, and it's based on mutual hate: "us" versus "them", "friend" vs "foe"."

50 But these distinctions are highly artificial. In real life, as everyone knows, human societies tend to exhibit both inclusion and exclusion—any community may be called a tribe, and any tribe a community. Nor is there anything consistently negative about the term "tribe". Some of us remember how, in 1996, PM Goh Chok Tong called on Singaporeans to embrace "tribes" as one of the three T's of Singapore's success.

55 The danger of a self-contradicting idea is that you can hear what you want to hear, based on, precisely, your tribe. Should you be part of a majority that is uncomfortable with minority groups, you can take comfort from Wong's speech that you are already a nation while the others are tribes. Should your tribe be a minority—in other words, no chance there of mistaking yourself for a nation—you would hear that your tribe should allow itself to be absorbed into the nation.

Unfortunately, those ensconced in the majority hear nothing in this distracting history lesson that would prompt them to different behaviour.

Unhelpful suggestions

60 Perhaps you think I'm giving Lawrence Wong a hard time—this is a complex world, and tribalism's a complex issue. So, instead, let's take a look at his practical suggestions on how to heal the divides between us. First, he says we've got to "strengthen our human relationships". OK, that works.

65 Second, we must "avoid stereotyping groups of people or assuming that each community is monolithic and homogeneous." He exhorts us to recall that "regardless of our gender or sexual orientations, regardless of the cause we champion, we are all Singaporeans, first and foremost."

Here, is where he is exclusionary. As my fellow respondent, AWARE Executive Director Corinna Lim pointed out at the panel, 40% of Singapore's resident population doesn't hold Singapore citizenship.

Non-Singaporeans, including Permanent Residents, are our neighbours, family members, teachers, and essential workers. Not even all the speakers at the IPS conference were Singaporeans. So Wong's
70 gone against his own directive, stereotypically assuming all Singapore residents are homogeneously Singaporean. The message to us is to avoid the problems of tribalism by identifying with the correct tribe—that of the Singaporean citizen. Such a message needs to be balanced out with strong language on the ugly flip side of national pride: xenophobia.

Lawrence Wong does concede, however, that “we can and must do a lot more to integrate foreign
75 workers in our midst” but only in his Q&A when brought up by an audience member. This is a phenomenon that hurts citizens too, as my other fellow respondent, Minority Voices co-founder Sharvesh Leatchmanan, explained. As an Indian Singaporean, he finds that his nationality is increasingly being questioned by others who are keen to police who does and doesn't belong on this island.

80 But let's move on to the third suggestion: to remember that “trade is in our blood”, i.e. that we should be open to cooperating with different cultures and communities because of “our instinctive desire to explore the unknown”. It's an on-brand metaphor, considering Lawrence Wong's portfolio as Minister for Finance. But it's wanting as a representation of the interaction between today's identity groups. How does the invitation to “trade” work with economically disenfranchised groups?

85 If we're talking about migrant workers or the disabled, does it make sense for us to relate to them on the grounds of “reciprocity, trust, and mutual benefit”? Is it fair to look at someone who's been marginalised by society and say, “Let's be friends, as soon as we can figure out how to profit from each other”? This suggestion assumes fair trade conditions, perfect knowledge between all parties, and that we are all moved by the profit motive. The first two do not exist in identity politics; while the non-
90 ubiquity of the last is a very reason why we are even having a discussion on identity politics.

Privilege vs power

Besides logic, there's another aspect of Lawrence Wong's speech that begs closer inspection. It's the way he misrepresents specific terms. For instance, “Chinese privilege”. He calls this a mere stereotype: a sloppy overgeneralisation of the diverse experiences of Chinese Singaporeans, who may be rich or poor, male or female.

95 But the term's much more nuanced than that. It's grounded in sociology, and, as a Mothership article explains, it's a way to encapsulate how Chinese folks don't usually face the same race-based obstacles as ethnic minorities in Singapore. By trivialising concepts associated with social justice, Wong—consciously or subconsciously—seems to be avoiding the fact that different groups have different power levels. When he describes the government serving as “a fair and honest broker”,
100 he's constructing a utopian scenario where every tribe has an equal amount of influence and numbers, where no group is ideologically committed to the erasure of another.

A hint of redemption

So do I think there was nothing redeeming about Wong's speech? Not quite. He's made statements that we need to hold on to. He's said that groups have the right “to organise themselves”; that the government “will never let any group feel boxed in or ostracised.” I hope that I am right to read this
105 as an encouragement to organise, speak up, and take action for under-represented groups and causes. Plus, I haven't mentioned Lawrence Wong's fourth suggestion: “as a society, we must continue to give all Singaporeans reason to hope and a fair chance to have a good life.” This isn't just an abstract expression of goodwill; he promises “targeted support with universal coverage for essential items”—a genuine effort to reduce inequality. It's an exceptional commitment, and I'm impatient to learn the
110 details and see it enacted.

And maybe I'm going a little crazy after parsing this speech for so long, but I think I've found something profoundly redemptive to it. Yes, there are layers of frequencies, sounding differently to different ears, but there *is* a driving melody. If you put aside the inconsistencies, at the core of his talk you'll find a fundamental opposition towards conservatism.

- 115 When Wong defines community as being “about inclusive connections”, and condemns tribalism as “inherently exclusionary”, he’s essentially telling us to be ruled less by taboos and more open to difference. He could well be praising the arts community, which has always been focused on dialogue and diversity. Or he may be speaking of the queer community, which has had to carry on constant negotiation to include all its members—not just gay, lesbian, bisexual and transgender, but now
- 120 pansexual, demisexual, asexual, non-binary, as well as a range of races, religious perspectives, classes, and political views.

- Still, as Corinna Lim said, it’s not enough to embrace a national tribal identity to unify everyone in Singapore. We need to endorse a common set of values. Fortunately, Singapore’s got an official set of five ideals, represented by the five stars on the flag. They stand for democracy, peace, progress,
- 125 justice, and equality—pretty inspiring stuff.

- The conservative tendency, which is all too common in Singapore, is to focus only on peace and interpret it as silence, submission, and obedience. But if we want everyone to feel counted, we must start talking more about the other national tenets: democracy, justice, and equality. And if we are brave enough to push for something better than the status quo—that’s progress. As it is, many parts
- 130 of the speech make little sense. It’s confusing and at parts, internally contradictory.

But if we—and I include both activists and the government here—work to reform this country a little more, then it can do something better than make sense.

It can make a real difference.

For discussion/reflection:

1. There are some examples of ‘identity politics’ from other countries presented in Reading 12 (lines 17-23). Identify and explain the instances of ‘identity politics’ you have observed here in Singapore.
2. Minister Wong suggests that the ‘rise of tribalism was linked closely to the rise of individualism’ (line 24). Attempt to articulate his line of reasoning.
3. Explain in your own words why Minister Wong says ‘ “Chinese privilege” is a form of stereotype’ (line 64).
4. Minister Wong lists principles of what the government has done – or must do – to ensure inclusivity in Singapore. In your opinion, how well has government policies embodied these principles (Reading 12, lines 58-91)?
5. Ng writes in Reading 13 that tribalism in ‘human societies tend to exhibit both inclusion and exclusion’ (line 48-49). What is the difference between a community that ‘may be called a tribe’ (line 49) and a ‘tribe [that may be called] a community’ (line 49-50)?
6. To what extent is it crucial for Singapore to foster a national identity? Analyse this by considering some of Singapore’s cultural, social, and political characteristics.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
2. ‘Race has no place in politics today.’ How far do you agree? (RI 2020 Y6 Prelim)
3. Assess the view that your society is not doing enough to eradicate prejudice. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 14: Budget 2026: Accelerating Singapore's growth in a fragmented world

EU 4 & 5

Lee Sze Yeng and Ajay Kumar Sanganerla | *Business Times* | 16 Feb 2026

This article helps you understand:

- **How Budget 2026 positions Singapore in an increasingly fragmented and uncertain global economy**, outlining strategic investments in innovation, AI, and enterprise transformation to ensure that the nation remains competitive amid geopolitical tensions, supply chain shifts and slowing global growth.
- **The Budget's dual focus on economic dynamism and social stability**, showing how support for businesses, productivity upgrades and digital transformation is balanced with measures to uplift lower-wage workers, strengthen retirement adequacy and manage cost-of-living pressures — reinforcing Singapore's model of growth with inclusivity.
- **How long-term structural challenges shape fiscal policy**, particularly the need to adapt to technological disruption, workforce ageing and global economic volatility.

Fragmentation is the new defining feature of the global trade environment. Amid this, Budget 2026 responds to a crucial question for Singapore: Can a small and open economy continue to succeed in the new world order?

5 While the current landscape presents **difficult trade-offs** – between artificial intelligence (AI) adoption and workforce stability, and between attracting global investments and developing local capability – Singapore's Budget posits these are **not contradictions but, rather, reinforcing strategies**.

The Budget represents a concerted national push for industry-wide transformation and comprehensive AI integration in the intelligent economy. At the same time, its targeted measures reflect the need for fiscal prudence amid heightened macroeconomic uncertainty.

10 Singapore is expected to end the 2025 fiscal year with a surplus of S\$15.1 billion, with a smaller surplus of S\$8.5 billion projected for FY2026.

15 On the whole, Budget 2026 plays to the Republic's clear strengths in areas such as advanced manufacturing, connectivity and services, while exemplifying the country's focused strategy for a new era of growth. Its measures will enhance **Singapore's appeal as a connector of international flows of people, markets and capital**, enabling the country to move decisively in the face of global change. But more crucially, the Budget seeks to advance Singapore's "We First" agenda, ensuring that businesses and individuals are not left behind as the country forges ahead.

The reinforcing cycle of trade complexity and capability

20 For Singapore to remain a crucial node, it will need to reinforce its status as a sophisticated hub for emerging technologies that can accelerate innovation across industries. This means continually setting a global benchmark for the effective integration and scaling of AI across industries, maintaining Singapore's competitive edge in the intelligent economy. It is also imperative that Singapore beefs up its guard rails to ensure that this integration is responsible.

25 Budget 2026 shows how Singapore is reinforcing its AI strategy to accelerate sound, technology-fuelled growth – across the economy and with a focus on specific areas that leverage the country's strengths. A new National AI Council chaired by Prime Minister and Minister for Finance Lawrence Wong will help to strategically accelerate Singapore's growth, while clear rules will enable Singapore to apply AI responsibly and safely across society. PM Wong also emphasised that Singapore must go beyond individual pilots to achieve speed and scale at a national level. Budget 2026 can then be viewed as a catalyst for deeper AI integration that spurs sustained economic transformation.

30 The launch of new national AI missions – in advanced manufacturing, connectivity, finance and healthcare – draws on Singapore’s existing strengths and will help to advance innovation in these well-established fields. The Productivity Solutions Grant will be expanded to support a wider range of digital and AI-enabled solutions, while a larger AI park at one-north – which builds on the Lorong AI community – will empower Singapore to turn pilots into real-world applications. These initiatives
35 could help identify new areas for AI-driven growth while potentially strengthening crucial discourse and action on technology governance.

Such efforts complement broader initiatives to reinforce Singapore’s competitiveness, including enhanced grant schemes to help companies internationalise, measures to increase funding for early-stage companies, and moves to shore up the attractiveness of Singapore’s capital markets.

40 In addition to increasing the limits and caps under schemes such as the Market Readiness Assistance and Double Tax Deduction for Internationalisation, the programmes have also been extended to non-local small and medium-sized enterprises. This empowers the entire business ecosystem to effectively navigate a challenging and volatile global environment.

Meanwhile, measures to build capabilities in alternative energy solutions and to green the aviation and maritime sectors reflect a continued focus on growth that is not only technology-powered, but
45 also sustainable.

When executed effectively, **the Budget’s initiatives will enable businesses to strategically and continuously integrate AI in response to evolving business needs**. Their success also hinges on companies’ willingness to readily adapt to AI-driven disruptions, cultivate fluency in the technology
50 across the workforce, and fill talent gaps by redesigning roles. This agile mindset is what Singapore needs to keep cultivating.

The social licence for speed

Budget 2026 will help drive workforce transformation by enabling individuals to acquire essential competencies such as AI literacy and skills. Easier access to premium AI tools will help to democratise upskilling, while clearer AI learning pathways aim to make career transitions and advancements
55 seamless. This helps to **address concerns about technological change coming at the expense of workers**. Such efforts will also enable Singapore talent to focus on higher-value activities, strengthening their attractiveness in the intelligent economy.

Singapore businesses and workers stand at the core of this transformation. As PM Wong highlighted, the goal is ensuring “every Singaporean who is willing to adapt and learn will continue to secure a
60 good job and make a good living here in Singapore”.

Critically, **initiatives to cultivate essential AI competencies also complement broader efforts to strengthen Singapore’s social compact**. These include enhanced co-funding support for the Progressive Wage Credit Scheme, as well as Central Provident Fund top-ups for older Singaporeans and those with lower retirement savings.

65 Even as the global environment poses seemingly impossible trade-offs, Singapore is actively refining its strategy to stay relevant. Now, businesses and individuals must also take charge of Singapore’s new journey of growth – by being ready to embrace change with agility, take calibrated risks, and confidently respond to what lies ahead.

For discussion/reflection:

1. The article frames Budget 2026 as part of a long-term strategy to “accelerate growth in a fragmented world.” What does this suggest about the government’s leadership approach towards

uncertainty and structural change? How does this strategic positioning reflect forward planning and national stewardship?

2. In prioritising AI and workforce restructuring, does Budget 2026 place excessive faith in technological advancement as the key to Singapore's survival, or is this emphasis both necessary and justified?
3. Analyse the implications of investing heavily in innovation and artificial intelligence while continuing to expand social safety nets. How do these priorities reflect the balance between economic dynamism and social equity? To what extent can Singapore sustain both competitiveness and inclusiveness in the long term?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Evaluate the effectiveness of government efforts to enhance people's quality of life in your society. (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
2. 'What an individual eats or drinks should not be the concern of the state.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2021)
3. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
4. 'The key to good governance is in staying accountable to the people.' How far do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
5. Do you agree that efforts by the government to ensure greater inclusion in your society have done more harm than good? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)

Additional reference:

- Download the MOF Budget Booklet 2026 and refer to pages 12-17 for measures mentioned in this article: <https://cms.singaporebudget.gov.sg/assets/e5fc5689-f5ca-4585-85a5-160f6ad04d37>

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 15: Decision on Section 377A reflects ‘Singapore formula’ on difficult issues

EU 2-4

Gillian Koh and Mathew Mathews | Channel News Asia | 24 August 2022

This article helps you understand:

- The government’s decision to repeal Section 377A but institutionalise a heterosexual definition of marriage through the Constitution
- How advocates on both sides of the debate have regarded the issue to be of fundamental importance, given the existential burden each felt they have borne
- That the issue is a value-laden one that cannot be definitively resolved and thus the government has decided that it must be held in a state of provisional stability
- That the proposed dual track policy reform is intended to achieve balance across diverse viewpoints, but could lead to greater polarisation
- The Singapore formula for managing difficult moral and political controversies, which involves shifting policy and legislative positions towards greater inclusion of minorities while simultaneously introducing measures to address the concerns of the majority community

At the 2022 National Day Rally, Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong announced that one, the Government will repeal the colonial-era law that criminalises sex between men and two, amend the Constitution so that the heterosexual definition of marriage as stipulated in the Women’s Charter and Interpretation Act cannot be challenged in a court of law.

- 5 The status of Section 377A in the Penal Code is in a special breed of political issues where advocates feel that their personal value system and way of life are at stake. The differences are viewed as irreconcilable. The best route in managing them is to find compromise solutions with the assurance that these can be reviewed from time to time. There will now be debate in Parliament but neither lobby should imagine it is the only valid group of stakeholders in the room, that no new ones will arise,
- 10 or that an assertion of rights can only be defined one way.

In his speech, Mr Lee did indeed recognise that some, presumably those advocating the repeal of Section 377A and equal citizenship for lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) individuals, will find the move too modest, while others, presumably those appealing for status quo to hold, will receive it with great reluctance. He added that no group can have it all their way.

Arguments on both sides

- 15 Over the past 15 years since Parliament last debated the status of Section 377A, the lobbies on both sides of the divide have strengthened, each treating it as an existential issue, each arguing that it has been stigmatised. The LGBT community, in particular, homosexual men, say they have experienced psychological duress because of Section 377A. The conservatives, taking reference from their peers in countries where laws on same-sex relations have been liberalised, fear the loss of their rights to preach
- 20 and teach about traditional (or heteronormative) values related to marriage and family.

This is an issue area that is not merely about rational policy issues where consensus, pragmatism and even legal coherence or integrity can be so easily arrived at. It is in a special category of public policy issues that can only see a state of “stable irresolution” as propounded by political theorist James Tully and written about by local scholar Johannis Auri Abdul Aziz.

- 25 This means that passionately-held, value-laden beliefs are admitted into the democratic process and for a time, a certain accommodation is accepted not only for the sake of upholding a higher order goal

of peace and the political system, but also because it is paired with the proviso that there will be space to contest policy and legislation at the next appropriate stage, whenever that may be. So, positions are “provisional” because they cannot be definitively “resolved”. The arrangement is held till claimant groups provide new reasons for legislative change.

A new accommodation

Singapore is one of the most diverse countries on the planet, not only in terms of religious beliefs including those who are agnostics or atheists, but also in terms of ethnicity and linguistic backgrounds. Once activated, the respective communities will be heard and felt viscerally.

With the planned dual track policy reform of Section 377A that is supposed to have benefitted from extensive discussion with interested segments of society, a new accommodation is proposed. The question is whether passionate advocates on either side will cause a greater polarisation of society, or if they will signal a belief that their interests are better served by accepting this new political arrangement and holding it steady for some time to come.

In its initial response, the LGBT community said the repeal of Section 377A would be a “hard-won victory” but was “dismayed” that there would be moves to defend the current definition of marriage. Its members said that the intention to repeal Section 377A would be but the “first step on a long road” towards equality.

In its response, a group of Pentecostal and Charismatic Christians said the decision was “extremely regrettable” but recognised that the Government was seeking to achieve balance across diverse viewpoints. There is deep worry that the ordinary laws on which the protection of the current concept of family in the Constitution is proposed, can be toppled by a simple majority in Parliament.

The Singapore formula

Civil contestation and the tone of it will make all the difference. Singapore has managed such difficult moral and political controversies before like the 2004 decision to license casinos within proposed integrated resorts. The introduction of a panoply of social safeguards and committed enforcement of them have kept the level of problem gambling and associated social problems relatively stable. The “wait and see” approach provided the space for this move which was similarly dual-sided – liberalise and protect – to prove its worth. In 2021, the Government announced it would change a long-held ban on the use of the tudung, an important part of a Muslim woman’s dress code, in the uniformed public healthcare sector. Mr Lee has said that the public has absorbed the change relatively well.

Examining these, policy and legislative positions have shifted in the direction of greater inclusion of minorities while other measures are introduced to address the concerns of the majority community or those representing the status quo. This has been the Singapore formula.

Let us use an imperfect but hopefully helpful analogy of team-sports to illustrate this political model and what it is not. Scenario One: After the final whistle, members of the vanquished team shake hands with the victors and referees, vowing to prepare themselves to take on their adversaries (not enemies) again. The spectators celebrate a game played in the spirit of sportsmanship, and look forward to the rematch. A month later, the teams meet but this time, to promote the city’s new integrated sports facilities and its sporting culture, a common interest they can all rally around.

Scenario Two: After the final whistle, members of both teams come to blows as they have made enemies of each other as the game ensued. The referees are caught in the scuffle because the players believe that the outcome was shaped primarily by the rulings of the referees. The fans also fight each

other. The facilities are damaged and there are injuries. A month later, there are campaigns to ban the sport and certainly shut down its association.

70 As citizens, we pledge to build a democratic society amidst our diversity in values and social mores whatever the source of inspiration or authority. Scenario One is what we must maintain. Scenario Two is what we must avoid. More talk with a large dose of empathy is, paradoxically, the action that is needed. Harassment and violence will take things beyond the pale. But unlike the analogy, the issue of Section 377A cannot be distilled into a game, and no side is actually “defeated”.

75 As a small, dense nation that also hosts many a sojourner, first, this political capacity to weave a strong tapestry that accommodates differences and creates common interests, and second, the human capacity to be creative and wise to generate specific accommodations to narrow the gap between policy trade-offs and competing interests, are what must make this union called Singapore, real and workable. We have done it before, we can do it again.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Why is the issue of Section 377A in the Penal Code such a difficult and sensitive issue in Singapore, and why is it unlikely to be resolved definitively in the near future?
2. How have the lobbies on both sides of the divide regarding Section 377A in Singapore evolved over the past 15 years, and what are the main arguments put forth by each side?
3. In your own words, explain the concept of ‘stable irresolution’ (line 23) and how it applies to the issue of Section 377A in Singapore. Can you identify and explain any other issues that Singapore may have to manage, for which this concept may also apply currently or in the future?
4. Summarise the response and arising concerns of both the LGBT community and conservative groups to the government’s proposed ‘dual track policy reform’ (line 34).
5. Explain the ‘Singapore formula’ (line 57) in your own words. How was this formula used to manage similar moral or political controversies in the past? What is your view of the ‘Singapore formula’? How convinced are you that it is an effective and/or necessary approach towards handling contentious issues in Singapore? Try to base your answer on your understanding of Singapore’s specific, even unique social, cultural, and political traits
6. What lessons can be drawn from the analogy of team sports in understanding the political model used in Singapore? What are the key distinctions between the two scenarios used by the authors?
7. In your opinion, how does the government’s handling of this issue demonstrate that it is trying to strike a balance between acknowledging diversity and continuing to emphasise the importance of societal solidarity?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent can any society claim to be great? (Cambridge 2020)
2. Should governments involve themselves in matters related to religion? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
3. How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
4. ‘The key to good governance is in staying accountable to the people.’ How far do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
5. Should individual rights and freedom be protected at all costs? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelim)
6. Assess the view that your society is not doing enough to eradicate prejudice. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
7. How far should governments interfere in the way individuals organise their lives? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
8. Consider the notion that reaching a consensus is an ideal way to govern. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
9. Should a government always listen to its people? (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
10. ‘A good government should always put the interests of the majority first’. Discuss. (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
11. To what extent is healthy debate encouraged in your society? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 16: Re-examining Singapore's social security system

EU 5

Adapted from New Options in Social Security, essay from 'Hard Choices' | Donald Low and Sudhir Vadaketh | 2014

This reading helps you to:

- Identify more of the programmes and policies within our social security system
- Recognise the need for a compromise between preserving the State's financial resources for the future and addressing the current needs of an aging generation
- Consider reasons why an expansion of Singapore's existing social security system may complement governance in the long term

Singapore's social security system is premised on the principles of individual and family responsibility, community help (sometimes referred to as the "Many Helping Hands Approach"), and government assistance as a safety net of last resort. Besides housing and healthcare, the main expressions of our social security system are the Central Provident Fund (CPF) system, to help Singaporeans achieve a certain degree of retirement adequacy – and more recently, Workfare – to encourage low wage workers to stay in work. For the chronically poor and others requiring targeted assistance, various programmes under the umbrella of ComCare have been developed in recent years, and delivered at the community level.

Weaknesses of our social security system

The three main innovations in our social security system over the last few years have been the Workfare Income Supplement (WIS), CPF LIFE, and the various efforts to enhance and increase the coverage of MediShield. The first addresses the problem of wage stagnation among low income earners through the government topping up the wages of low wage workers; the second addresses longevity risks by introducing social insurance⁴ into a system that has otherwise relied mainly on individual savings; while the third addresses the risks of catastrophic illnesses by increasing insurance benefits for a wider range of medical conditions and treatments, and by extending coverage to previously excluded citizens.

These measures are important steps in strengthening our social security system. But the system still has significant gaps and is not sufficiently robust for three main reasons.

First, Singapore's social security system provides hardly any protection against the risks of involuntary unemployment. Workfare is aimed at employed, low-wage workers in the formal sector (roughly corresponding to the bottom fifth of the income distribution). CPF savings cannot be withdrawn before the individual reaches the age of 55. Even the subsidies that the government channels into various training programmes are mostly mediated through employers. While the unemployed are not excluded from these training subsidies, the principle of co-payment requires them to fork out their own monies to benefit from government subsidies in training and skills upgrading. We should think hard about how we can provide lower- and middle-income Singaporeans better protection against the risks of involuntary unemployment without creating significant risks of moral hazard.

Second, for the majority of Singaporeans, our social security system relies mostly on the principle of individual savings. With the exception of the subsidies in healthcare, MediShield and CPF LIFE, Singaporeans do not fully benefit from social insurance and the power of risk-pooling to deal with contingencies such as a loss of earnings, disability, or an extended period of illness. They are almost

⁴ public insurance program that provides protection against various economic risks (e.g., loss of income due to sickness, old age, or unemployment) and in which participation is compulsory

entirely reliant on their own accumulated resources to deal with such episodes of income instability. While self-reliance is a good principle in general, if taken to extremes, it may neither be efficient or just. We should think hard about how our social security system can find a better balance between individual savings, social insurance and direct subsidies.

Third, despite Singaporeans having one of the world's highest savings rates and highest social security contribution rates, many Singaporeans struggle with attaining retirement adequacy. For instance, among active CPF members who reached 55 years in 2009, only 37.5 per cent had met the Minimum Sum stipulated by the government with both cash and a property pledge, and only 20 per cent could meet the Minimum sum wholly in cash. This means that four out of every five active CPF members who turned 55 in 2009 did not have sufficient cash to meet their basic needs in old age if they did not have sources of financial support other than their CPF savings.

This lack of retirement adequacy has different causes for different segments of the population. Among lower-middle to middle-income Singaporeans, this is, in large part, due to the fact that so much of their CPF savings are locked up in housing. While housing represents a store of value that can be unlocked for retirement needs, this presumes that monetisation incurs relatively low costs. The fact is monetisation options are currently quite limited, not to mention households that need to unlock their housing assets may be doing so in the wrong part of the property cycle. While the lease buyback scheme introduced by government in 2008 is a step in the right direction, it is also incumbent on the government to develop more monetisation options for older Singaporeans.

Among the poorest Singaporeans, poverty both in terms of difficulties meeting basic needs (i.e. the bottom 10 per cent of working households) and the lack of retirement adequacy (i.e. the bottom 30 per cent of working households) arises from the fact that their wages are barely enough to cover basic needs. The solution for this smaller segment of the population will probably need to be some combination of increased Workfare (especially the cash component), direct subsidies to meet their basic needs, and government assistance to pay for medical and longevity insurance.

Principles for reforming out social security system

Singapore's social security system needs to be enhanced and reformed along two key principles. First, in the context of intensifying global competition, low-wage competition and rapid technological change, Singapore is likely to experience a more rapid technological change, Singapore is likely to experience a more rapid pace of economic restructuring, increasing economic volatility and higher income inequality. If so, Singapore's social security system needs to be expanded to go beyond simply meeting the retirement, housing and healthcare needs of Singaporeans to also providing a cushion and buffer against rapid economic change and adjustment. Such a social security system will facilitate the process of economic restructuring. It will also help our workers transit from one industry to another as the economy moves up the value chain, provide them greater protection against periodic bouts of unemployment and income instability, and enable them to save enough for retirement. Seen in this light, an expanded social security system is an essential counterpart of our basic economic strategy of globalisation and plugging into the global economy.

Second, well-designed social protection programmes can be achieved through the careful incorporation of social insurance into our social security system. Our own experience in healthcare financing provides a "model" for how the overall social security system should evolve. In healthcare, the government has accepted that it is neither efficient nor equitable for individuals to save for large medical bills arising from catastrophic illnesses, and it has – over time – expanded the use of medical insurance to deal with more of these risks and contingencies. In dealing with longevity risks, the government has also come to accept that such risks are best dealt with through risk-pool and social insurance in the form of CPF LIFE.

Constructing a more robust social security system that provides Singaporeans greater protection against the uncertainties and vagaries of the global economy is an economic, not just a social, imperative. By providing Singaporeans greater social protection, the government builds public support

for the tough policy choices necessary in globalisation and economic restructuring: attracting and integrating foreign talent, outsourcing or relocating lower value-added jobs, maintaining flexible labour markets, and increasing Singapore's integration into the global economy. A more robust social security system also gives Singaporeans a stronger stake in the nation, enabling government to use social insurance programmes to foster social cohesion.

Ensuring intergenerational equity

A third major area that needs to be carefully re-examined in the context of our baby boomers entering retirement is intergenerational equity and how our reserves can be optimally deployed to help us cope with an ageing society.

On intergenerational equity, perhaps the most important fact is that it is the baby boom generation that contributed the most to the accumulation of national reserves. A significant part of our reserves is the result of fiscal surpluses generated in the 1980s and 1990s – the period when the baby boom generation was most economically productive. Indeed, we should view the reserves accumulated as a net transfer from the baby boom generation to the state. Now that the generation that contributed the most of our reserves is entering retirement, it is only fair from an intergenerational perspective that the state reverse part of that transfer. To impose the fiscal burden of looking after the needs of the baby boomers onto subsequent generations in the form of higher taxes while continuing to accumulate reserves is not only inequitable but also inefficient.

A likely objection to the proposal to set aside part of our reserves to fund the needs of the elderly is that this represents a raid of our reserves, which the current Constitutional rules on the protection for reserves were designed to forbid. But this objection ignores the fact that the rules on the use of reserves were formulated at a time (the early 1990s) when Singapore was still generation large fiscal surpluses and the concern then was how we can set aside sufficient resources to deal with future contingencies. It is timely and necessary for government to review how the rules on the use of reserves should be adapted for a radically different context.

Conclusion

The current social compact served Singapore well for the first 40 years of its nationhood. It ensured growth with equity, and delivered good education, a fiscally sustainable social security system, good basic healthcare, housing for all, and an excellent infrastructure. Nothing in this paper is meant to diminish the achievements of the Singapore government in building the current social compact.

At the same time, the social compact as it is currently conceived is not adequately equipped to deal with the forces unleashed by globalisation, technological change, and Singapore's own policies. The socio-political and economic contexts are also changing, and strains are already showing in our social and political fabric. These trends suggest that the Singapore state needs to reinvent and expand the current social compact.

The policymaker's reflexive belief that an expansion of social security will erode our work ethic and reduce national competitiveness may have been appropriate for a previous era. These widely held beliefs and assumptions are not entirely unjustified; they were probably necessary and largely correct for an earlier context. But these may now be precisely the things that hold the government back from thinking creatively and comprehensively about today's inequality and how it should be addressed over the long-term. What is needed therefore is a return to the innovative, integrated, pragmatic and adaptive approach that characterised the Singapore government when it first formulated the current social compact and built institutions like public housing and the CPF.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Why do you think that the Singapore government has, in our social security system, chosen not to emphasise unemployment benefits?

2. The authors suggested that 'self-reliance is a good principle in general, [but] if taken to extremes [may] neither be efficient or just' (lines 34-35). Explain the nominal benefits of promoting self-reliance as a principle in social policy. What would taking it 'to extremes' look like, and why might it be inefficient and/or unjust?
3. This article was published in 2014. Consider the developments that have taken place between then and now. How far have policymakers addressed the gaps and issues highlighted by the author?
4. According to the author, why might it be said that a 'more robust' (line 79) social security system ultimately aids governance?
5. The authors argue that '[t]he current social compact [had] served Singapore well for the first 40 years of its nationhood' (line 107). Based on lines 107-111, what do the authors suggest Singapore's social compact constituted, at that point of writing (in 2014)?
6. Summarise the authors' reasons for why this social compact 'is not [adequate]' (line 112). Reading 6 outlines how the Forward SG exercise aimed to 'review and refresh Singapore's "social compact"' (pg. 25, line 6) and proposes 'seven key shifts' (pg. 26, line 33). How well might the proposed shifts address the authors' misgivings about the previous social compact?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which all people in your society have the opportunity to achieve their full potential. (Cambridge 2023)
2. To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest? (Cambridge 2020)
3. Evaluate the effectiveness of the government's efforts to enhance people's quality of life in your society. (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
4. To what extent is poverty the fault of the individual? (RI 2019 Y6 Prelim)
5. Consider the view that we do not take enough responsibility for our own well-being. (Cambridge 2018)
6. How far is increased prosperity for all a realistic goal in your society? (Cambridge 2013)
7. Should your government do less for its people? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
8. Should governments prioritise social welfare above overall economic growth? (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)

Supplementary readings

- [2026 Budget Debate - Tax Exemption Bracket to Move with Times](#) (2026, Mothership, Singapore): *Member of Parliament (MP) Saktiandi Supaat called for the personal income tax exemption threshold in Singapore to be raised from the current \$20,000 to \$25,000/ \$30,000, arguing that the threshold has remained unchanged for over two decades and needs to "move with the times" to reflect current economic realities.*
- [The Ultimate Showdown: CPF \(SG\) vs EPF \(MY\) Vs 401K \(USA\)](#) (2024, Dollars & Sense, Singapore): *This comparison highlights the key difference of each social support system. You can also refer to this [chart](#) to gain a better sense of the pros and cons of each system.*

SECTION C: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN INCLUSIVENESS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Reading 17: Immigration and the future of the Singapore identity

EU 5

Melvin Tay & Mathew Mathews | *The Business Times* | 24 December 2025

This reading highlights:

- The tension between Singapore's economic necessity for openness and the social anxieties surrounding immigration.
- That while Singaporeans value multiculturalism, there is significant ambivalence regarding how newcomers affect national identity.

Few in Singapore need to be told that openness brings opportunities. Global capital, regional headquarters, international schools, and myriad talent from around the globe is an integral part of the operating environment here.

5 But with growing immigration over the past decades, it is unclear whether Singaporeans are feeling more open, or more guarded about who gets to be part of "us." As illustrated by a number of our studies, Singaporeans remain proud of their country and comfortable with diversity, but are unsure about how immigration fits into the national story.

This matters for business: The ability to attract and retain people is ultimately constrained by host population acceptance.

What Singaporeans are telling us

10 In our most recent study, respondents were first asked a simple open-ended question: "What does it mean to be Singaporean?"

The answers were reassuring: The majority of responses cited multiculturalism, a sense of belonging, pride in the country, and value placed on living peacefully with others.

15 At the same time, immigration clearly emerges as a societal fault-line. Close to two-thirds of respondents felt that believing in diversity or having been born elsewhere did at least sometimes strengthen or weaken national identity.

When asked whether new citizens and foreigners strengthen or weaken Singapore's identity, the public was split: Roughly one-third thought newcomers exert a positive effect; a quarter felt they make no real difference, and about four in 10 saw their impact on our identity as negative to some degree.

20 Those who took a dimmer view often worried about cultural dilution. To them, values, language, and loyalty might be eroded, as well as competition for jobs and perceived lapses in everyday norms.

In contrast, those who were more positive pointed to cultural enrichment, innovation, demographic renewal, and the energy brought by people who choose to put down roots here.

25 The picture that emerges is not one of a closed or hostile society. It is a society that still believes diversity is part of who we are, but is not certain about how fast, and on what terms, that diversity should grow.

A familiar pattern beyond Singapore

These ambivalent attitudes are not unique to Singapore. Research worldwide shows that diversity brings both opportunities and complications.

30 Economists Alberto Alesina and Eliana La Ferrara, reviewing data from cities and countries around the world, argue that ethnic and cultural diversity can boost productivity and innovation. But it is also associated with lower provision of shared goods and redistributive policies if institutions are weak or inequality is high.

35 Meanwhile, sociologist Robert Putnam's well-known work on US communities suggests that in the short term, rapid increases in diversity can lower social trust and civic engagement, even as they hold the potential for richer "bridging" ties in the long run.

Other studies from Europe reach similar conclusions: Immigration and diversity do not automatically destroy social cohesion; but where economic insecurity is high and integration policies are weak, they can become a lightning rod for frustration.

40 The OECD's recent *International Migration Outlook* stresses that countries only fully reap the gains from migration when newcomers are effectively integrated into education systems, labour markets, and local communities, and when host populations feel that this process is fair and well-managed.

In other words, how Singaporeans feel about valuing openness, yet worrying about fairness and cohesion, is not a uniquely Singaporean problem. It is a common challenge among advanced economies plugged into global flows of people.

Two contrasting experiences of openness

45 Even within Singapore, people are not experiencing openness in the same way. Younger adults in our study were generally more positive about newcomers. Many have grown up with classmates, colleagues, and friends from different countries. For them, immigration is part of a normal, globalised life. A significant share in this group felt that new citizens and permanent residents strengthen cultural diversity, social cohesion, and values.

50 In contrast, respondents in their 50s were most sceptical. For them, immigration is more likely to be seen through the lens of job competition, cost of living, and pressure on services. The same is true, on average, for lower-income respondents compared with higher-income ones. Both groups can see the macroeconomic benefits arising from immigration, but they disagree on whether these benefits reach their households.

55 If we ignore these differences, we risk talking past each other. One Singapore sees openness as opportunity, while the other experiences it in the form of sharper competition.

The good news: Our "We" is still civic

Despite all this, the core of Singapore's identity remains civic rather than ethnic. More than nine in 10 respondents in the IPS-CNA study on national identity said they were proud to be Singaporean and would rather be citizens of Singapore than any other country.

60 In an earlier 2021 IPS study on national pride and identity, we asked Singaporeans what newcomers needed to do to become "one of us." Respondents emphasised respect for the law, tolerance of other races and religions, and belief in equality and fairness. Cultural conformity, such as speaking local languages or sharing particular customs, ranked lower.

65 This is not how every society approaches identity. In some countries, birth, ancestral ties, and ethnic background remain the main gatekeepers. The fact that Singaporeans still see citizenship in largely civic terms where contribution and commitment matter is a major strength. Our national "we" can, in principle, accommodate new citizens who live here and embrace our local values and norms.

70 At the same time, immigration tests whether we really mean what we say. If we retreat into informal hierarchies of "true-blue" versus "paper" Singaporeans, we weaken the very idea that has allowed a small, diverse society to stay cohesive while remaining open.

Towards a more confident openness

What would it take to move from being "open for business, uneasy in our hearts" to embracing a more confident, sustainable openness?

75 First, we need to acknowledge prevailing anxieties without writing them off as xenophobia. When people worry about job security, housing, or their children's prospects, they are often expressing vulnerability, not hostility to diversity per se. Addressing these concerns, as the government has done through a range of policy measures—whether through generous grants for skills upgrading or anti-discrimination measures through the Workplace Fairness Act—strengthens the social licence for immigration.

80 Second, we must double down on the civic basis of our national identity. A large majority already believe that having a strong identity contributes to success, unity, and stability. The more clearly we define "being Singaporean" in terms of contribution, responsibility, and belief in multiracialism, the easier it becomes to explain why some newcomers are welcomed into the circle and expected to further strengthen national identity.

85 Third, we should recognise that integration is a two-way process. International work on migrant integration consistently stresses that both newcomers and host societies must adapt: newcomers by learning norms and laws, and hosts by keeping pathways of trust and participation open. Businesses can play a direct role here through mentorship programmes, inclusive HR policies, and internal communication that treats diversity as a shared asset rather than a fault-line.

90 From the crucible of separation and independence in 1965, our founding leaders chose openness as a condition for survival for our small island with no natural hinterland. We had to plug ourselves into the world or be left behind. That founding choice still defines us today.

95 Singapore will not return to being a closed, insular economy. Our demography, geography, and economic model make that impossible and undesirable. But while we are very much open for business, the harder test—in the years ahead—is whether we can stay open in our hearts, while holding firmly to the civic values that make this city worth building a life in.

For discussion/reflection:

1. In the section "What Singaporeans are telling us" (lines 14-37), what are the positives and negatives of embracing new citizens?
2. From lines 40-62, what complications are raised by the increase in diversity?
3. The article states that "the core of Singapore's identity remains civic rather than ethnic" (line 80). What implications are raised if our national identity shifts towards "ethnicity"?
4. With reference to the section "Towards a more confident openness" (lines 100-129), what are some examples already manifested in Singapore that promote openness? How effective are they?

Supplementary readings:

- **Singapore must do more integration as immigration is crucial amid low birth rate (The Straits Times, Jan 2026):** Minister Jeffrey Siow warns that Singapore's "abysmal" fertility rate, which hit a new low of 0.87 in 2025, makes immigration economically vital. However, he emphasises that successful immigration depends on better integration, requiring a mutual effort from both locals and newcomers to preserve social cohesion and national identity. Watch the speech [here](#).
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- **Rules of engagement for an honest debate on Singapore's immigration policy (The Straits Times, Jan 2026):** *This article highlights the need for Singaporeans to move beyond polarised rhetoric. Both the government and citizens should balance economic needs with social anxieties, ensuring newcomers integrate while locals feel heard and protected.*

Related case studies:

 [**Syrian migrants in Turkey have built businesses despite challenges. Here's what has helped them succeed \(Turkey, 2025, Conversation\):**](#) *By the end of 2024, 42.7 million people were forcibly displaced worldwide, with many in Turkey establishing businesses to rebuild their lives. Success for these entrepreneurs hinges on fostering a host country identity through language proficiency and timely legal protection, while promoting inclusion and early support initiatives are crucial.*

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'In the global village in which we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
3. Is a thriving economy the best measure of a good government? (2023 Y6 Prelim)
4. Should refugees be viewed as a burden in modern society? (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
5. 'A nation that simply complains.' Is this a fair comment about your society? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)
6. How far is your society prepared for the challenges that diversity brings? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelim)
7. 'Migration creates more problems than it does solutions.' Discuss. (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)
8. To what extent should your society welcome immigrants? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)

SECTION D: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN DOMESTIC INTERESTS AND GLOBAL CONCERNS

Reading 18: Singapore's approach to the challenges of an uncertain external environment **EU 6**

Speech by Minister for MFA Dr Vivian Balakrishnan [adapted] | Committee of Supply Debate | 3 March 2025

This reading will help you to understand:

- How the rules-based international order is increasingly challenged, and why upholding it remains important for Singapore's security and prosperity.
- How credibility, reliability, and principled engagement allow Singapore to navigate a complex world, maintain trust with other countries, and uphold its values even when global pressures test its principles.

This is the tenth time that I am addressing the Committee of Supply (COS) as the Minister for Foreign Affairs, and I have never seen the world more disrupted, more volatile, or more dangerous. The *post-World War liberal world order was characterised by free trade, multilateral institutions, and international law and treaties to protect the global commons*. Unfortunately, the world is now **shifting from unipolarity to multipolarity, from free trade to protectionism, from multilateralism to unilateralism, from globalisation to hyper-nationalism, from openness to xenophobia, from optimism to anxiety**.

First, on the economic front, the US has progressively shifted to a more nationalist approach, in response to what it deems to be unfair trade measures and free riding. The **new US administration** clearly sees **tariffs as a means to address non-trade-related policy objectives, including national security, local job creation, more resilient supply chains, and bargaining leverage**. Other major countries are also using similar restrictions on trade more frequently, and not always confining themselves to trade-related issues. **Tariffs are being applied to partners, competitors, and adversaries alike**. The US has announced tariffs on Canada, Mexico, and China, and in turn, these countries have also signalled retaliatory measures. **Tit-for-tat tariffs by other countries can easily escalate into a global trade war**.

Singapore, so far, has not been targeted directly. But even if we are not, we will still be affected. These **tariffs will have a major impact on the volume and the pattern of world trade, and significantly affect us**. The first level is as a transshipment hub with all the other global services we provide the world. There will be *supply chain disruptions and more volatile prices*. There are also implications on the global financial system and the way frontier technology⁵, which some of you have referred to, is being developed, shared, and exploited. All these **levers — tariffs, financial systems, and technology — may be weaponised**. Because Singapore operates as an open economy that is deeply integrated with all the big powers around the world, we trade, invest and access technologies with all of them. We are a vital node in a global network. We connect and enable inter-operability. The **Singapore model is based on trust, openness, and a level playing field**. We allow companies from all over the world to operate here as long as they play by the rules. That is how Singapore has survived and thrived for six decades. This **open paradigm** that has served us so well for six decades, **is now at risk**.

Second, regarding war and peace, **Russia's war on Ukraine has caused the transatlantic relationship with the US to be under strain**. NATO members are now seriously and urgently rethinking their strategic and security situation, and their policy options. Closer home, tensions in the South China Sea continue to simmer. The Taiwan Strait remains a potential flashpoint, and we all know that tensions have increased in recent years. **The rules-based international order that has prevailed for 80 years, is at risk of degenerating into the "law of the jungle", where might makes right**. International law, the UN Charter,

⁵ Emerging, cutting-edge, and fast-growing technology (e.g. AI, robotics, biotechnology) designed to disrupt existing processes, fundamentally transforming how society communicates, works, and lives.

the principles of sovereign equality, political independence, and territorial integrity have all been severely eroded. And by definition, this must mean the loss of choice and autonomy for small states. I recall a speech that Mr Lee Kuan Yew gave back in 1973 at the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting. He referred to an old African proverb, “when elephants fight, the grass suffers”. But he added one additional line — “when elephants make love, it is disastrous”. The point is, **when big powers are on the move for whatever reason, it is a dangerous time for all of us.**

Third, **our ability to respond collectively to global threats and safeguard the global commons has been significantly impaired.** The collective commitment to international institutions like the WTO, WHO, as well as compliance with international treaties like the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) and the Paris Agreement that resulted from it, are all waning. **Imagine, is the world today in a better state to deal with another pandemic, given a severely weakened WHO? And how are we going to respond to climate change, if we do not have the institutions and the processes to protect the global commons?**

Now let us return to Singapore. Our **foreign policy** begins at home, and it must always be a **balance between realism and idealism.** It means we must have no illusions about our place in the world. But small as we are, for 60 years, **we have refused to adopt a fatalistic posture.** We have insisted on agency to build our strength, to protect our sovereignty, maintain our relevance, to create political and economic space for ourselves. We strive to be useful, but not to be made use of. And, of course, to avoid becoming a sacrificial pawn between big powers.

Now, I have dwelt at length on the dangers arising from the end of the previous world order. The point is, I am making an appeal for us all to be alert, to be realistic, and to be careful in these dangerous times. But a note of caution is not a call for pessimism. Because in fact, **Singapore has good reason to have confidence in our future, due to the pioneering work of past generations.** Today, we are in a strong position. Our core strengths are based on three key pillars: first, **our economic strength and our reserves;** second, **our ability to stand on our own two feet and to defend ourselves;** and third, **our domestic cohesion.** Because of our strength economically, we cannot be bullied or bought. We have significant national reserves and if the biggest criticism that we face in this Budget debate is budget marksmanship and having more reserves than we anticipated, I think that is reason for celebration, considering the circumstances in which we are going into. This is an enormous advantage. On the international stage, if you have to put your hand out for assistance, it means you have no say. It is a big advantage for Singapore not to have to beg for aid. We have no need for assistance or loans that will subject us to external pressure. We are not dependent on any single external partner. And perhaps even more importantly, we do not depend on any external country to defend Singapore. We have the capability and the will to defend ourselves. For six decades, we have invested fiscal resources approved by Parliament, and every man in this Chamber, and his sons, has served National Service. The fact that everybody knows that we are good for our money, and we put our blood where we stand on, is the core of deterrence and respect.

Unity at home

But all this is not enough if we do not have unity at home. And we **need to live up to the Pledge to be one united people, regardless of race, language, or religion.** Our diplomacy works because we have painstakingly forged and maintained domestic consensus on our core long-term interests and foreign policy priorities. Now, our diversity in Singapore does mean that from time to time, Singaporeans will have different views on developments around the world. And we **have to provide space for this diversity to be expressed, but without allowing it to become a means to divide us as a country.**

A clear example is the **disaster in Gaza.** It is a deeply emotional issue. Let me be clear that when we make our **foreign policy decisions,** we do so on the **basis of national interests.** The attack by Hamas on 7 October 2023 was an act of terror. No ifs, buts, root causes, or justifications. And it is why that in the aftermath of that attack, we had strongly reaffirmed the right to self-defence. You see in the case of both

80 Ukraine and Hamas, we took positions for our own sake, for our own national interest, and not because we were taking sides. At the same time, that **right of self-defence must be consistent with international law, humanitarian law and the Geneva Conventions**. And that is why we told Israel directly and personally that Israel's military response has gone too far. And we say all this because it is in **our national interest for international law to be upheld**, and not to be flouted. Singapore's longstanding position on
85 the Israeli-Palestinian issue is that the only path to a just, durable, and comprehensive peace is a negotiated two-state solution.

But that is not enough, because we all do feel deep sympathy for the immense suffering of the civilians in Gaza. And thus far, Singapore and Singaporeans have contributed seven tranches of aid and monetary donations to Gaza, worth over S\$19 million. It is crucial, therefore, that we stay united and keep being
90 able to adopt this collective, constructive approach, even when we have different views on events and tragedies far from our shores.

And the reason — a deeper reason why we need to do this — is because, *if conflict broke out nearer in Asia, it will have not only even greater emotional resonance, it will have a larger economic impact and it will also elicit a range of reactions from our people, and will be even harder to manage*. It is also worth
95 remembering that there will always be external actors who will try to influence the views of our people and take advantage of our diversity. We can have different views, but we will stay united and we will close ranks on issues of national interest, so that we can ultimately secure what is best for Singapore.

Foreign policy in tumultuous times

Let me turn now to the question of, **how are we going to conduct our foreign policy in these tumultuous times?** You do not know what is going to happen next, but you know that we are living in dangerous
100 times. So, fundamentally, our foreign policy must continue to be **anchored by longstanding principles that have kept us afloat for six decades**, even whilst we make tactical adjustments or even strategic adjustments to our approach. We must maintain an omni-directional, balanced, and constructive engagement with all partners.

Relations with major powers

105 So, how can we continue to build on our honest and constructive relations with the US and China amidst their rivalry? I believe it is crucial that we **maintain our ties with both countries given our significant equities with both**. The US is the largest foreign investor in Singapore by far. It is our top trading partner in services, and it is our third largest trading partner in goods. Meanwhile, China is our top trading partner in goods. Many of our companies are invested in China, and of course we have strong people-to-people
110 ties, historical and cultural ties. Both the US and China are also at the frontier of many leading technologies, whether it be AI, biotechnology, or green energy. **We will never be the largest trading or strategic partner to either China or the US — basically because we are a small country. But we can be amongst their most reliable and consistent partners**, and that is valuable and appreciated by both of them. We have maintained our relevance and credibility with both powers by being consistent, by being
115 transparent and being constructive. And both of them know, that when Singapore takes a stand, it is not because we are doing it at the behest of its rival, but that we take a stand because we have done our own calculation of what is in our long-term enlightened, national interest.

Our immediate neighbours

We must continue to **strengthen our ties in our region**, bilaterally especially and most extensively with Malaysia and Indonesia, and obviously, with **ASEAN**. We will continue to do so on the basis of
120 **interdependency, mutual respect and aim to build healthy relations which will be crucial for stability and growth of our entire region**. Both Singapore and Malaysia have committed to not allow any single issue to overshadow our overall positive agenda, and we are pursuing mutually beneficial projects, both bilaterally and regionally, to strengthen connections and connectivity for the long term. With Indonesia, the Expanded Framework Agreements on airspace, defence and extradition entered into force last year.

125 This was a major achievement. We are making **good progress including in areas like renewable energy, human capital development, and particularly in the fields of education and healthcare.**

Our region

ASEAN was founded in 1967 on the principle that **‘either we hang together or will be hung separately’**. Given that we are now entering another dangerous, volatile phase, this concept of ‘hanging together’ has just become **even more salient**. **ASEAN** so far has been able to maintain regional peace and stability, and
130 enabled all of us collectively to focus on economic growth, and, in particular, economic integration. **ASEAN’s convening power will remain relevant and important** in the years ahead, to ensure that whilst we do not want to be an arena for proxy wars, we do want to be a **safe harbour where all powers will have a stake in our success and that we can maximise opportunities and autonomy** for **ASEAN Member States**. We must also do far more with each other and **double down on ASEAN’s economic integration** in
135 order to improve our collective value proposition and collective resilience – especially in food and energy.

Global partnerships

Beyond our immediate neighbourhood, it is also crucial for us to **make common cause with as many partners as possible** including India, Japan, the Middle East, Africa, Europe, Latin America, Australia, New Zealand, and the Pacific Islands. We already have an extensive network of 27 FTAs that covers 90% of our trade. Even though free trade has had a setback, we can still make common cause with those who believe
140 it is a formula for mutual peace and prosperity. We have got to keep that flame going. For instance, we have been able to sign new free trade agreements in the last few years, including Mercosur (Argentina, Brazil, Uruguay, Paraguay) in 2023 and the Pacific Alliance (Peru, Chile, Mexico, Columbia) in 2022. We believe these will expand markets and increase opportunities for us. We are also pressing ahead on the digital economy. Singapore, New Zealand and Chile signed the Digital Economy Partnership Agreement in
145 2020. We have also concluded negotiations on the EU-Singapore Digital Trade Agreement in July 2024. We agreed to elevate relations with India to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. We will continue to work closely with Japan. We have also upgraded relations with the UK and Germany to Strategic Partnerships. We are also stepping up engagement of Africa, a centre of growth for the future. So, as you can see, we have been working very hard on this strong, wide network of partners with whom
150 we can trade, invest, do business with, and engage in constructive partnerships on these emerging issues.

UN and Multilateralism

At the UN, we continue to be a **staunch advocate for multilateralism, for the adherence to international law and for the importance of the UN Charter. This system is vital for countries big and small in order for us to have a chance to compete on a level playing field**. Singapore must and will remain a strong supporter of multilateralism. We will make common cause, and we will stand up for this. This is why we
155 established the Forum of Small States (FOSS) back in 1992, which now has 108 members. FOSS is a platform to foster closer cooperation, reinforce multilateralism, and support the developmental aspirations of small states, and we will continue to strengthen and improve the existing international architecture and ensure that it is fit for purpose. **Our mantra is: it is better to reform than to risk a revolution that will destroy the old regime completely, because the alternative is bad for small states.**
160 This is why we welcomed the adoption of the Pact of the Future, the Global Digital Compact, and the Declaration on Future Generations at the Summit for the Future in 2024. This was a significant milestone for the international community. It demonstrated that the UN is still able to arrive at consensus and able to advance the agenda for collective good.

International law is also important for us. UNCLOS (The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea) provides the legal framework that ensures that freedom of navigation and overflight is a right and is not exercised only by the grace of any resident big power. Without UNCLOS and the right of transit passage, Singapore would effectively be “sea-locked”. Despite the challenges, **with patient and skilful diplomacy, it is still possible to arrive at international agreements by consensus**. Another recent example was the adoption of the BBNJ (Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction). This Agreement was

170 settled in June 2023. Our Ambassador Rena Lee presided over the intergovernmental conference, very skilfully managing to bring all parties together and arrive at a treaty by consensus. We are nominating her for the International Court of Justice (ICJ) elections due in November 2026.

Staying open and seizing new opportunities in new frontiers

Staying open and nimble in seizing new opportunities in technological frontiers has also been the other cylinder for Singapore's success. The short answer to the question on how to maintain our access to
175 frontier technologies is: openness and trust. We must actively create opportunities that will enable Singapore to be a magnet for ideas, technology, talent, and capital.

We already have actively advanced cooperation with a range of like-minded partners on emerging technology. This includes our partners like the US, China, India, UK, Japan, Germany, France and Australia.
180 **We remain clear-eyed that there is strategic contestation between the major powers, and it does complicate our attempts to create an open platform. Nevertheless, we remain plugged into international conversations on technology standards and norms setting, in line with our own national interests.** Our Permanent Representative to the UN in New York, Mr Burhan Gafoor, serves as the Chairman of the UN Open-ended Working Group on security of and in the use of ICT. He works intensively with the entire international community to advance policy discussions, norms and generate practical
185 solutions to preserve international peace and security in cyberspace and maximise opportunities.

Domestically, our strong rule of law and trust in our system will be crucial if we want to be able to **attract and retain technology** and — I need to emphasise — **talent** from all over the world. Singapore **cannot afford to exclude anyone** — any technology, any company with access to frontier ideas, frontier technologies. If we are going to seize the opportunities in frontier technologies, we need to be prepared
190 to complement the Singaporean workforce in order to gain access to ideas and technology. But having said that, **everyone who comes here, and any company operating here**, wherever you are from, will have to **play by the rules**. We will take firm action and move decisively against errant individuals and companies that flout our domestic laws. We do not condone companies taking advantage of their association with us to engage in evasive, deceptive or dubious business practices for short-term
195 commercial advantages, because that actually sullies and takes unfair advantage Singapore's reputation.

For discussion/reflection:

1. The speech warns that “tariffs, financial systems, and technology...may be weaponised” (line 20), and that Singapore’s open paradigm “is now at risk” (line 26). In a world where economic interdependence can be used coercively, how advisable is it for Singapore to remain “omni-directional” and “balanced” (line 102) in our foreign policy?
2. With the “rules-based international order...at risk of degenerating into the ‘law of the jungle’” (lines 31-32), how should Singapore respond if the international system increasingly reflects “might makes right” (line 32)?
3. What does the metaphor “when elephants fight, the grass suffers” (line 36) reveal about small-state diplomacy?
4. What does a “fatalistic posture” (line 48) mean in the context of small-state diplomacy?
5. The Minister notes that commitment to institutions like the WTO and WHO is “waning” (line 42), yet insists that Singapore “must and will remain a strong supporter of multilateralism” (lines 153-154). To what extent can multilateralism remain effective if major powers selectively comply?
6. How can Singapore uphold unity at home while still providing space for different views on international issues?
7. How should Singapore navigate emotionally-charged global conflicts while preventing them from “becom[ing] a means to divide us as a country” (line 75)?

8. Compare the 2019 and 2025 Committee of Supply speeches. What remains constant in Singapore's foreign policy approach, and what appears to be under strain in light of rising protectionism, weakened multilateralism and intensified major-power rivalry?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. How far should countries have relations with others whose human rights record is poor? (Cambridge 2019)
2. A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations. (Cambridge 2019)
3. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
4. To what extent is diplomacy effective in dealing with conflicts today? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
5. 'Small countries are helpless in shaping global politics.' Do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelim)

Supplementary reading & discussion question:

- In a March 2019 speech, Foreign Minister Dr Vivian Balakrishnan outlined Singapore's foreign policy principles: safeguarding sovereignty, upholding a rules-based international order, maintaining strategic autonomy, and strengthening multilateral and bilateral partnerships. ***Compare this earlier speech with the one in the reading above: What remains constant in Singapore's foreign policy approach, and what appears to be under strain in light of rising protectionism, weakened multilateralism and intensified major-power rivalry?***

SECTION D: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN DOMESTIC INTERESTS AND GLOBAL CONCERNS

Reading 19: Singapore responds to criticism of its climate pledges

EU 6

Adapted from Analysis panning Singapore's climate targets as 'critically insufficient' lacks nuance: Government | Audrey Tan | The Straits Times | 22 September 2021

This reading will help you understand:

- How Singapore navigates the tension between domestic interests and global concerns within the context of climate change
- Singapore's climate targets and decarbonisation journey
- The unique challenges Singapore faces as a small city-state

A climate research consortium has pegged Singapore's climate targets as being "critically insufficient" - the worst rating on a five-point scale - putting the nation alongside Iran, Russia, Saudi Arabia and Thailand.

5 But the Government has refuted the Climate Action Tracker assessment, saying the analysis lacks nuance, as it does not account for constraints faced by the country in its decarbonisation journey, such as its high population density and limited access to various renewable energy sources. The Climate Action Tracker is a collaboration between two Germany-based research organisations - Climate Analytics and the New Climate Institute.

10 It analyses the climate pledges of 39 countries and the European Union, covering the biggest emitters as well as a representative sample of smaller emitters, which together contribute about 80 per cent of global emissions. The Republic contributes about 0.11 per cent to global emissions.

What the report said about Singapore

15 On Sept 15, Climate Action Tracker published its analysis for Singapore's climate targets, ranking them as being "critically insufficient". This is the worst rating on its five-point scale. The other four are: highly insufficient, insufficient, almost sufficient and 1.5 deg C Paris Agreement compatible. Only one country - the Gambia - has targets deemed suitable for the highest category.

Nations whose targets were labelled "almost sufficient" include Britain, Nepal, Costa Rica and Ethiopia.

20 Jurisdictions with "insufficient" pledges include the European Union, the United States, Germany and Japan, while countries with "highly insufficient" pledges include Indonesia, China, Australia and India. Under the Paris Agreement, nations must take progressive action to reduce their carbon footprint so the world has a greater chance of limiting warming to 1.5 deg C above pre-industrial levels - the threshold to which warming must be kept to avoid harsher climate impacts.

25 On this front, Singapore said in its updated climate pledge last year that the country's emissions will peak at 65 million tonnes by 2030. This means that even if the economy continues to grow, the amount of emissions produced should not. Over a longer time horizon, Singapore wants to halve the amount of emissions it produces from its 2030 peak by 2050, with the aim of achieving net-zero emissions "as soon as viable in the second half of the century".

30 But the Climate Action Tracker said Singapore's rating showed that the nation's climate policies and commitments "reflect minimal to no action and are not at all consistent with the Paris Agreement". "If fully implemented, Singapore's current policies would result in emissions reductions beyond its targets, but still only in line with 3 deg C warming," the analysis added. "Singapore needs to set a more

ambitious target for emissions reductions and establish associated policies to improve its Climate Action Tracker ratings."

Singapore government responds

35 In response to this assessment, a spokesman for the National Climate Change Secretariat (NCCS) told The Straits Times that the Government is still reviewing the methodology. But he added: "Our preliminary sense is that the Climate Action Tracker may not have fully accounted for our unique challenges as a small city-state with limited access to alternative energy sources."

40 The spokesman said Singapore's population density is more than 10 times higher than the next densest country in the Climate Action Tracker list, South Korea. He added: "Given our lack of land, Singapore is unable to pursue the same types of solutions as the other countries on the list, for example hydro or nuclear power." But Singapore is still working to manage its emissions within these constraints through careful long-term planning and innovations in policy and technology, he said.

45 Singapore's energy mix has a low proportion of coal at 1.2 per cent, compared with other countries, including Japan's 29.8 per cent and Germany's 29.2 per cent, said the NCCS spokesman citing Bloomberg data. Coal is the dirtiest form of fossil fuel. Singapore relies largely on natural gas, a fossil fuel cleaner than coal, for its energy needs. More than 95 per cent of its energy comes from this source.

50 The NCCS spokesman also said Singapore is exploring ways to diversify its energy mix by harnessing greener options such as solar energy, clean energy imports, and low-carbon alternatives.

The Government is also reviewing the trajectory and level of the carbon tax, post-2023, in consultation with industry and expert groups. He added: "Even as we implement existing initiatives, we also look to enhancing our sustainability goals and actions. Singapore is committed to doing our part to contribute to the global fight against climate change, through tangible action."

55 Climate policy observer Melissa Low from the National University of Singapore's Energy Studies Institute, acknowledged the country faces constraints in decarbonisation. She said Singapore's updated climate target is closely linked to its first one, and represents progression from an emissions intensity to an absolute peak target.

60 Under the Paris Agreement, countries are urged to make new or updated pledges every five years, so that national climate action is periodically ratcheted up. But as these pledges are determined by nations, it also means that countries are not obligated to submit entirely new ones. They could, for instance, simply resubmit what they had pledged to do in their first one.

65 Under the first pledge made in 2015, Singapore's main goal was to become greener economically and reduce the amount of greenhouse gases emitted to achieve each dollar of gross domestic product by 36 per cent from 2005 levels, come 2030. It also pledged to stop any further increases to its greenhouse gas emissions by the same timeline.

70 In its updated climate pledge last year, Singapore committed to the absolute peak emission level of 65 million tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent by 2030. Ms Low said the Government had publicly said that Singapore, in the formulation of its 2030 target of reducing emissions per dollar of GDP, had already expected emissions to stabilise at around 65 million tonnes of emissions by then if the former was achieved.

"The aim to peak emissions highlights that Singapore will work towards reducing emissions after 2030," she said. "The enhanced target allows for better accountability but is not necessarily more ambitious."

For reflection/discussion:

1. Should small states like Singapore be judged by the same Paris Agreement (1.5°C) and Climate Action Tracker standards as large, resource-rich countries, or should geographic and resource constraints justify different benchmarks for their climate targets?
2. Apart from Singapore's small land size, which the NCCS spokesperson suggested as being a constraint in what we can do to meet climate targets (lines 39-42), what other "unique challenges" (lines 37-38) do we face? Consider this in terms of social, political, and geopolitical factors. Are there factors we possess that are in our favour when it comes to meeting environmental challenges?
3. How should Singapore balance its role as a fossil fuel hub with its climate commitments?
4. In your opinion, does Singapore's carbon tax sufficiently contribute to the global fight against climate change? What else could Singapore do to make a greater impact?
5. Given that climate agreements are not legally binding, and pledges are entirely determined by countries, how might that impact global efforts in addressing climate change?
6. What other critical areas or stakeholders that also play an instrumental role in combatting climate change are there, which are not adequately represented by climate pledges/targets?

Related essay questions:

1. A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations. (Cambridge 2019)
2. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
3. How far do you agree that good governance is key to the protection of the environment? (2021 Y6 Prelim)
4. Should environmental sustainability be given greater priority in your society? (RI 2021 Y6 Common Test)
5. How far should governments interfere in the way individuals organise their lives? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
6. 'The environment should be the responsibility of the individual, not the government.' Comment. (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)

Supplementary reading:

- **What Does the Singapore Green Plan Have to Do With Us? According to These Youths, Everything (Rice Media, 5 October 2021):** *This article highlights how Singapore's Green Plan 2030 connects with youth. Young Singaporeans engage with sustainability through green habits, advocacy, and initiatives in areas like waste reduction and sustainable business. These youths stress the importance of environmental education, inclusive decision-making, and active participation to achieve the plan's goals.*
- **Singapore and International Efforts (National Climate Change Secretariat, 2021):** *Singapore aligns with the Paris Agreement, aiming to peak emissions around 2030 and achieve net-zero by mid-century. Having exceeded its 2020 emissions reduction pledge, it continues to pursue international cooperation, regional partnerships, and knowledge-sharing, while balancing climate ambition with economic competitiveness and technological readiness.*
- **Singapore's climate action has been graded 'highly insufficient', but is that too harsh? (CNA, 2024):** *The article argues that Singapore's rating must be viewed in light of structural constraints. As a small, densely populated city-state with limited land, it cannot deploy large-scale renewables like wind, hydro or geothermal, and faces limits in expanding solar energy. Its continued reliance on fossil gas and the economic role of the fossil fuel sector further complicate decarbonisation. Despite measures such as carbon pricing and green building standards, these constraints make rapid alignment with Paris Agreement goals difficult.*

SECTION D: NEGOTIATING BETWEEN DOMESTIC INTERESTS AND GLOBAL CONCERNS

Reading 20: Imposing sanctions on Russia despite potential costs

EU 6

Adapted from Why Singapore Has Chosen to Impose Sanctions on Russia | Xirui Li | The Diplomat | 9 March 2022

This reading will help you understand:

- That the sanctions help demonstrate Singapore's commitment to the international community and support the rule of law
- Why Singapore's decision is also driven by her strategic interests, which are reinforced through the preservation of a stable and peaceful global environment
- The challenges Singapore faces in balancing her strategic interests with its commitment to international norms and values, given the risks of doing so
- How Singapore's conduct in this conflict can serve as an example of how small states can play a meaningful role in global security

Despite being far away from Ukraine, the government of Singapore has not only voiced its condemnation of Russia's invasion, but has also taken the rare step of imposing unilateral sanctions on the country. According to the Singaporean Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the sanctions will focus on "export controls and blocking of certain financial transactions connected to Russian banks and financial institutions."

Indeed, Singapore's move is rare in the sense that all of the sanctions that Singapore authorities currently impose on other states are based on United Nations resolutions. Indeed, the last time that Singapore imposed unilateral sanctions was more than 40 years ago, when Vietnam invaded Cambodia and overthrew the communist Khmer Rouge.

Details of the sanctions have yet to be released, but they will likely focus on export controls, which are likely to come at some cost to Singapore, and blocking of certain financial transactions connected to Russian banks and financial institutions.

Rare though the move may be, it is not surprising. Singapore's swift, strong response to the Ukraine-Russia war, especially the imposition of unilateral sanctions on Russia, is consistent with its foreign policy. The decision is rooted in Singapore's perceived leadership role among small states and its long-time concerns and worries about the survival of such states in the international system. It was triggered by the malfunctioning of existing international institutions. Meanwhile, the relatively remote relationship between Singapore and Russia has also enabled the city-state to be more vocal and brave in its stance than it otherwise might have been.

Boasting only 728 square kilometres of territory, Singapore is one of the smallest nations in the world. Since its independence in 1965, Singapore's leaders have been well aware of its small size and the vulnerabilities that come with this. Therefore, the rights of small states in world affairs enjoy an official and prominent place in Singapore's foreign policy. Moreover, being a small and developed state, Singapore has taken it upon itself to represent the world's small states. In the hope that small states could be given more "strategic weight" in the United Nations, in 1992 Singapore established and has chaired the Forum of Small States, an informal and non-ideological grouping of small nations.

Similarly, in 2009, to address the unfair treatment of small- and medium-sized states by the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development and to create synergy between the G-20 and the U.N., Singapore set up another informal grouping of 30 small- and medium-sized members of the U.N. known as the Global Governance Group. In addition, Singapore has also participated in two other small-state groupings, the Alliance of Small Island States and the Small Island Developing States.

Another big concern for Singapore is the survival of small states. Of course, survival is a concern for any state, but for small states like Singapore, it is undoubtedly more pressing due to their vulnerabilities and relative lack of strength in the world system. Some are pessimistic about the survival of small states, pointing out that this is primarily determined by the international political environment rather than by the states themselves.

Recognising the vulnerability of the survival of small states in the world system, Singapore has long advocated for the principles of international law and the U.N. Charter, which underscores the respect for territory integrity and sovereignty. Therefore, Singapore has been consistent in its stand of firmly opposing any kinds of invasions, especially in cases when smaller states have been invaded by bigger powers, such as when Indonesia invaded East Timor and Vietnam, backed by the Soviet Union, invaded Cambodia. As Foreign Minister Vivian Balakrishnan told Parliament last week, “Ukraine is much smaller than Russia, but it is much bigger than Singapore.” By swiftly condemning Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, Singapore does both speaks for itself and acts as a leader and representative of the world’s other small, vulnerable states.

It is not the first time that Singapore has been vocal in condemning Russian actions. In 2014, when Moscow invaded Crimea, Singapore strongly objected, stating that “Russian troops should not be in Ukraine in breach of international law” and that “the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Ukraine must be respected.” Meanwhile, although expecting the U.N. to take steps to stop Russia, Singapore has also realized that the U.N. Security Council (UNSC) may not be able to undertake any meaningful actions for small states like Ukraine given the fact that Russia enjoys a veto as a permanent member of the Council.

Following the invasion, Russia vetoed a UNSC resolution condemning its own actions. The malfunctioning of the U.N., and its inability to safeguard its Charter and the principle of territorial integrity and sovereignty, is clear source of alarm to Singapore. Therefore, to show its responsibility as a leader among small states, Singapore decided to condemn Russia and take the rare step of imposing unilateral sanctions on the country.

Why has Singapore taken a stronger stand against Russia than its Southeast Asian neighbours, which has led some to conclude that Singapore is straying away from the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)? Part of the reason is that Singapore is less linked to Russia both economically and militarily. Trade with Russia makes up an insignificant proportion of Singapore’s total trade. It is true that countries in Southeast Asia are major buyers of Russia’s arms, but Singapore is an exception. According to the SIPRI database, the number of arms bought from Russia by Singapore was too small to be listed. On the other hand, Vietnam bought 80 percent of its total imported arms from Russia, Laos 47 percent, Myanmar 40 percent, and Malaysia 26 percent. Therefore, comparing Singapore to the ASEAN member states whose condemnations of Moscow’s actions mentioned neither Russia nor the word “invasion,” such a stance does not come at a price for Singapore. Not only that, the city-state’s brave action stands even to enhance its reputation as a principled member of ASEAN and a leader of the world’s small states.

For reflection/discussion:

1. According to Li, why is it ‘not surprising’ (line 13) that Singapore has decided to impose sanctions on Russia?
2. What are the implications concerning the ‘survival of small states’ (line 32), given their ‘relative lack of strength in the world system’ (line 34)?
3. In what ways might it be of paramount importance for small states like Singapore to show their support for a rules-based world order?

4. The author suggests that Singapore has taken a 'stronger stand' (line 58) against Russia's decision to invade Ukraine compared with her ASEAN neighbours. How might Singapore's position impact its relations with other countries, particularly those with closer ties with Russia?
5. What principles or values underpin Singapore's decision to impose sanctions on Russia, and how can this be applied to other similar issues faced by Singapore or other small states in the future?

Related essay questions:

1. A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations. (Cambridge 2019)
2. 'In the global village in which we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
3. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
4. To what extent is diplomacy effective in dealing with conflicts today? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
5. 'Small countries are helpless in shaping global politics.' Do you agree? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelim)
6. Should young people take a more active interest in politics, even when it is not directly relevant to their lives? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
7. 'A country should take care of its own interests before others.' What is your view? (RI 2018 Y5 CT)

Supplementary reading:

- **Sanctions against Russia come at economic cost to those imposing them** (Margaret Allen, Channel News Asia, 8 April 2022): *This article discusses Singapore's rare decision to impose unilateral sanctions on Russia following the invasion of Ukraine. It evaluates the inevitable economic trade-offs, including rising electricity and petrol prices and disrupted supply chains. Despite these costs, the commentary argues the move is essential to defend international law and national sovereignty.*